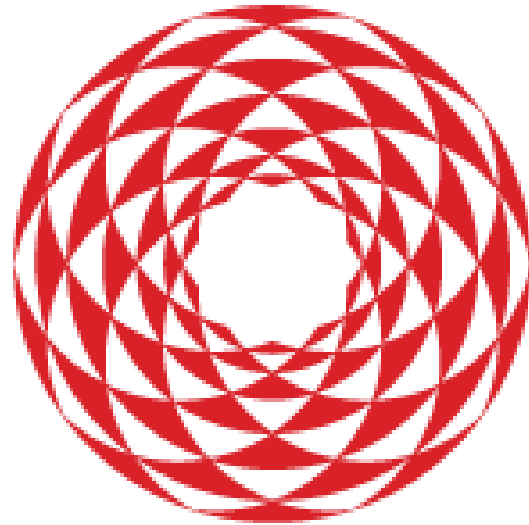




ashoka
UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF VISUAL ARTS

HANDBOOK Academic Year 2024-25

	<u>Contents</u>	
1	Introduction to the Department of Visual Arts	3
2	Pathways for Current Students-Requirements	5-9
	a. Minor	
	b. Concentration	
	c. New Credits Requirements for UG 2024 - 2028 students	10-14
	d. Minor	
	e. Concentration	
3	Cross-listing Policy for Visual Arts	15
4	Undergraduate 4th Year Guidelines	16-17
5	Internships in Visual Arts	18
6	Frequently Asked Questions	19
7	Studio Guidelines	20
8	Course Catalogue (Monsoon 2024 to Spring 2025)	21
	a. Courses offered by the Department - Gateway Courses	21-35
	b. Courses offered by the Department - Elective Courses	35-78
	c. Courses Offered by Visual Arts in the past currently not on offer	78-89
	d. Image Gallery of Museum, Gallery, Site Classes and Exhibitions	93-100
9	Past Visual Arts Student Testimonials and Present Affiliations	101-103
10	Dedication, to the Memory of Professor Kavita Singh	104

The Department of Visual Arts

Introduction

The Department of Visual Arts at Ashoka University combines courses in Art History, Visual Culture with basic training in select materials and media practices. While the Art History and Visual Culture courses offer historical and philosophical contexts in which visual arts has been developed and practiced, the studio courses facilitate the students in learning the fundamentals of art practice. Bridging the disciplinary divides of theory and practice, the department is focused on interdisciplinary perspectives in the contemporary field of Visual Arts.

Gateway Courses

The gateway courses are compulsory courses for choosing Minor or Concentration pathways for students. They are designed to offer a thematic overview of various disciplines and media practices that constitute the field of Visual Arts. These courses are offered across Art History, Visual Culture and Art as Practice.

Given the University's geographical and cultural location, the gateway courses introduce the students to the visual worlds of South Asian Art in its diverse discourses of forms and media. These courses offer critical training to some of the basic terms and methods of reading histories of art as part of larger global cultural formation.

Gateway courses also explore sites of disciplinary formations, display of art and provide introductions to various forms of contemporary practices of art.

Elective Courses

Elective courses provide students the possibility of exploring and engaging with various social, cultural and political frameworks as disciplinary protocols across the field of Visual Arts.

These courses are offered to introduce a range of areas and specific aspects of disciplinary enquiry.

Elective courses often extend beyond geographic and cultural locations to raise larger questions around language, media and context specificities of the visual image. These courses engage with processes of production, reproduction, circulation and the impact of these images on the viewing public, exploring the shifting temporal and cultural locations of major art movements and dwelling on recent methodological challenges of the discipline.

Electives are designed thematically to engage and orient students towards research paradigms and address specific concerns that are central to the disciplinary fields that constitute the realms of Visual Arts. Elective courses on offer are subject to change depending on faculty availability.

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Student Representative AY 2024-25			
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Pathways for Present Students

Requirements for Minor and Concentration

Apart from taking individual courses based on students' personal interest, the department offers two pathways for students to professionally pursue a Minor or Concentration in Visual Arts.

These two pathways open students' eligibility in specific arts domains and provide a comprehensive area introduction for further studies in Visual Arts.

Minor in VA:

To pursue a Minor in Visual Arts, students must complete **six courses** in Visual Arts. These include courses offered by the Department along with those offered by other departments and cross-listed with Visual Arts (code VA).

For UG/ASP 2022 and onward: Four of the six courses taken should be gateway courses.

The four **gateways** are a balanced mix of courses across art history and art practices, and they are:

1. **Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present**
Monsoon Semester
2. **Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art**
Spring Semester
3. **Arts of our Times I (Mediums and Media in Contemporary)**
Monsoon Semester
4. **Arts of our Times II (Media as Material of Practice)**
Spring Semester

Rest of the two courses from the six mandatory courses for Minor pathway, can be any of the elective courses being offered by the department or cross listed courses from Visual Arts and other departments (For a detailed list of elective courses, please scroll down to see courses on offer during the academic year 2024-25.) For complete list of cross-listed courses, please refer the Ashoka Management System (AMS)

ASP Rules and Credits in for Minor in Visual Arts for Present Batches

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – **total 24 credits** (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, + 2 elective courses, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

1. **VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art:** From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)
2. **VA - 2004 Arts of our Times** (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)
3. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights:** Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)
4. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II:** Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

Set - Minimum 8 credit(s) required from the courses of VA, any level Electives set Code Range: VA- (1000-4999)

Visual Arts Thesis – 4 credits

UG Rules and Credits for Minor in Visual Arts for Present Batches

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – **total 24 credits** (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, + 2 elective courses, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

1. **VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art:** From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)
2. **VA - 2004 Arts of our Times** (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)
3. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights:** Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)
4. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II:** Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

Set - Minimum 8 credit(s) required from the courses of VA, any level Electives set Code Range: VA- (1000-4999)

Concentration in VA for Present Batches:

UG Rules and Credits for Concentration in Visual Arts for Present Batches

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – **total 16 credits** (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, + 2 elective courses, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

1. **VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art:** From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)
2. **VA - 2004 Arts of our Times** (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)
3. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights:** Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)
4. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II:** Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

ASP Rules and Credits for Concentration in Visual Arts for Present Batches

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Concentration in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – **16 credits** (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

1. **VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art:** From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester) – 4 credits
2. **VA - 2004 Arts of our Times** (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester) – 4 credits

3. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights:** Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester) – 4 credits
4. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II:** Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester) – 4 credits

To pursue a concentration in Visual Arts, one must complete these **four courses** in Visual Arts. These include courses offered by the Department along with those offered by other departments and cross-listed with Visual Arts (code VA).

For UG/ASP 2022 and onward: All four courses (numbered 1, 2, 4, and 5) taken should be gateway courses, which are:

1. **VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art:** From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)
2. **VA - 2004 Arts of our Times** (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)
3. **VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History** (This is a compulsory course which is offered either as a taught course or ISM restricted in Monsoon Semester only to students pursuing a 4th year capstone Visual Arts or cross listed Visual Arts Thesis. The decision to open it as a taught course or ISM is dependent on Faculty Availability.)
4. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights:** Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)
5. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II:** Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

The Department recommends this sequence for the Visual Arts Gateway courses for batches graduating 2022 onwards.

The department also recommends doing the two parts of Arts of our Times courses. However, it is not mandatory to take these courses sequentially.

Please note:

*Gateway courses are offered once every academic year, and sometimes over the Summer Semester. Offerings in Summer Semester will be announced in advance during Spring Semester of the academic year.

None of the Visual Arts Gateway courses, **except VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History**, have any prerequisites. For taking up **VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History**, students should have

ideally completed at least three 2000 level Visual Arts Courses and should be ideally working on an UG/ PG Visual Arts thesis or on a UG/ PG thesis cross-listed with the Visual Arts Department.

Rest of the two courses can be selected from the range of elective courses for Minor pathway (4+4), can be any of the elective courses being offered by the department or cross listed courses from Visual Arts and other departments (For a detailed list of elective courses, please scroll down to see courses on offer during the academic year 2024-25.) For complete list of cross-listed courses, please refer the Ashoka Management System (AMS).

Students can gain 2 internship credits and 2 UGTA credits by internship with a museum or Gallery.

All Major Minor Courses are 4 credits each.

New Credits Requirements for UG 2024 - 2028 students

From UG 2024 – 2028 the credit requirements for Visual Arts Minor and Concentration have been changed in accordance with Ashoka University's Credit policies.

4 Years UG Rules and Credits in for Minor in Visual Arts for UG 2024 - 2028 students

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – 24 credits (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, + 2 elective courses, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)

VA - 2004 Arts of our Times (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)

VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)

VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II: Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

Set - Minimum 8 credit(s) required from the courses of VA, any level Electives set Code Range: VA- (1000-4999)

Visual Arts Thesis 4th Year thesis – Presently under review by Offices, to be declared later

The Department recommends this sequence for the Visual Arts Gateway courses for batches graduating UG 2024 – 2028 onwards.

The department also recommends doing the two parts of Arts of our Times courses. However, it is not mandatory to take these courses sequentially.

4 Years UG Rules and Credits for Concentration in Visual Arts for UG 2024 - 2028 students

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Concentration in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – 16 credits (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester) – 4 credits

VA - 2004 Arts of our Times (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester) – 4 credits

VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester) – 4 credits

VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II: Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester) – 4 credits

To pursue a concentration in Visual Arts, one must complete these **four courses** in Visual Arts. These include courses offered by the Department along with those offered by other departments and cross-listed with Visual Arts (code VA).

For UG/ASP 2022 and onward: All four courses (numbered 1, 2, 4, and 5) taken should be gateway courses, which are:

- 1. VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)**
- 2. VA - 2004 Arts of our Times (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)**
- 3. VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History (This is a compulsory course which is offered either as a taught course or ISM restricted in Monsoon Semester only to students pursuing a 4th year capstone Visual Arts or cross listed Visual Arts Thesis. The decision to open it as a taught course or ISM is dependent on Faculty Availability.)**

4. **VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)**
5. **VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II: Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)**

The Department recommends this sequence for the Visual Arts Gateway courses for batches graduating 2022 onwards.

The department also recommends doing the two parts of Arts of our Times courses. However, it is not mandatory to take these courses sequentially.

Please note:

*Gateway courses are offered once every academic year, and sometimes over the Summer Semester. Offerings in Summer Semester will be announced in advance during Spring Semester of the academic year.

None of the Visual Arts Gateway courses, **except VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History**, have any prerequisites. For taking up **VA-IS-4003-1 Methods in Art History**, students should have ideally completed at least three 2000 level Visual Arts Courses and should be ideally working on an UG/ PG Visual Arts thesis or on a UG/ PG thesis cross-listed with the Visual Arts Department.

Rest of the two courses can be selected from the range of elective courses for Minor pathway (4+4), can be any of the elective courses being offered by the department or cross listed courses from Visual Arts and other departments (For a detailed list of elective courses, please scroll down to see courses on offer during the academic year 2024-25.) For complete list of cross-listed courses, please refer the Ashoka Management System (AMS).

Students can gain minimum 2 and maximum 4 internship credits across Major Minor Programme across the entire 4 years.

3 Years UG Rules and Credits for Minor in Visual Arts for UG 2024 - 2028 students

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – 24 credits (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, + 2 elective courses, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)

VA - 2004 Arts of our Times (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)

VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)

VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II: Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

Set - Minimum 8 credit(s) required from the courses of VA, any level Electives set Code Range: VA- (1000-4999)

Students can gain minimum 2 and maximum 4 internship credits across Major Minor Programme across the entire 3 years.

New 3 Year UG Rules and Credits for Concentration in Visual Arts for Incoming Batches

Minimum Credit Requirements for VA Minor in the current ASP/ 4 years UG system – 16 credits (2+2 gateways/ compulsory courses each course 4 credits, each course 4 credits)

ISM courses – Minimum 0 and Maximum 8 credits Allowed

TP Credits – Minimum 0 and Maximum 4 credits allowed

Cross-listed Courses – Maximum 2 courses allowed

Set - Minimum 16 credit(s) required from the courses of Gateway Set which are:

VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1 Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present (Monsoon Semester)

VA - 2004 Arts of our Times (Mediums and Media in Contemporary) (Monsoon Semester)

VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1 Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art (Spring Semester)

VA-3054/ MS-3291 Arts of Our Times II: Media as Material of Practice (Spring Semester)

Please note:

***Gateway courses are offered once every academic year, and sometimes over the Summer Semester. Offerings in Summer Semester will be announced in advance during Spring Semester of the academic year.**

Rest of the two courses can be selected from the range of elective courses for Minor pathway (4+4), can be any of the elective courses being offered by the department or cross listed courses from Visual Arts and other departments (For a detailed list of elective courses, please scroll down to see courses on offer during the academic year 2024-25.) For complete list of cross-listed courses, please refer the Ashoka Management System (AMS).

Students can gain minimum 2 and maximum 4 internship credits across all Major Minor Courses.

All Major Minor Courses are 4 credits each.

Monsoon semester Gateway offerings 2024:

Histories of South Asian Art

Arts of our Times I

Spring Semester Gateway offerings 2025:

Sites and Sights

Arts of our Times II

*The listing of Gateway and Elective Courses is provided in the Course Catalogue and is subject to change.

Note: No combination of co-curriculars would count as a minor/concentration elective course for visual arts as it has been in the past.

Cross-Listing Policy

While some of the courses offered by Visual Arts are cross listed with other departments, the Department of Visual Arts also houses cross listed courses offered by other departments. This is integral to the spirit of interdisciplinary enquiry that we seek to foster at Ashoka University.

Please note that all cross-listing decisions are interdepartmental decisions, keeping in mind the pedagogic objectives of specific departments and courses.

Minor:

For UG/ASP 2024 and onward: A student **completing a Minor in Visual Arts** can take one such cross-listed elective course offered by another Department in conjunction with Visual Arts to count towards their minor.

Concentration:

For UG/ASP 2022 and onward: The number of permissible cross listed courses for students **pursuing a concentration in Visual Arts** offered by other Departments is zero, since there will be no academic space available for any, as all four courses will be gateway courses.

Undergraduate 4th Year (formerly ASP year)

Students pursuing a 4 years Undergraduate degree have the possibility of taking their 4th year in Visual Arts with an inquiry focused in the discipline. Ideally students would have completed their minor in VA by the end of 3 years (6 courses). However, if a student wishes to pursue Minor in their 4th year, they are eligible to do so by completing all 6 courses (4 gateways and 2 electives) in their 4th year.

Students can opt for a capstone/ UG 4th year **thesis** in any major or minor department.

Students can choose to write an Undergraduate Capstone in their 4th year of undergraduate studies in Visual Arts.

Students have the possibility of creating their own capstone project according to their areas of interest.

The Department of Visual Arts encourages and accepts 4th year students to take up Independent Study Module (ISM) or capstone thesis in VA, in both Art history and Art Practice, on the efficacy of their project synopsis.

The Department allows them the flexibility to house their capstone thesis with a chosen mentor within the department.

Students who have completed their Minor in VA are eligible to apply for Capstone thesis in Visual Arts.

For ISM guidelines are set by the Office of Academic Affairs. The Department follows these mandated ISM guidelines in Art History or Art Practice. Students intending to pursue an ISM should get in touch with respective faculty members and their initial email should be copied to the current HoD.

Guidelines

A thesis with the Department can be of two kinds:

1. Visual Arts Thesis

- Requirement for this include a concentration in Visual Arts
- The student, along with completing the thesis, will be required to take two visual arts elective courses to complete a Minor in the ASP year.
- For Art History/ Visual Culture thesis, students have to complete *Methods in Art History* offered in the Monsoon semester, either as an ISM or a full taught course depending on the availability of the course schedule of the instructor.

2. Interdisciplinary Thesis

- Such a thesis can be co-hosted by any other Department at Ashoka University along with the Visual Arts Department
- It is preferred that the student has done some visual arts gateway or elective courses. Students pursuing Minor or Concentration are eligible.
- Home and host departments collaborating on the thesis need to be mentioned in the SOP, along with preference of mentors from VA.
- The SOP must mention certain specific areas of concern/ research interests in Visual Arts

The process to apply for an capstone thesis in the Department is as follows:

The student is encouraged to reach out to faculty within the Visual Art Department under whose supervision they're interested in developing their thesis further. The student has to subsequently submit the following documents:

1. Statement of Purpose: Addressing areas of research, specific set of questions; making a case for their interest in the field of visual arts; identification of the problem, its scope, and the approach they will take. (Word limit: 500-1000 words)
2. Writing Sample of about 1500-2000 words.
3. If a student is interested in pursuing a practice based approach during their ASP in visual arts, a portfolio revision must be submitted to the Department at the point of application.
4. Covering Letter
5. Academic CV: Important areas to highlight are list of courses completed at Ashoka, extracurricular activities/achievements, internships, publications. Additionally, no personal details except the student's name and email ID are required.
6. Any other accompanying documentation such as artwork.
7. Further discussions about viability of ASP (Ashoka Scholars' Programme - Undergraduate Capstone year including thesis) and MLS (Masters in Liberal Studies) thesis need to be discussed on lines of methodology course/ courses to be offered by the Department.
8. Timeline of the project.

Internships in Visual Arts

All internships undertaken for credit scores by our students will need monitoring and credit policing by individual Ashoka mentors from the department, including our visiting faculty. Students can pursue internships in museums, galleries, conservation and other organisations that work with the Arts. Internships range from Arts management, arts administration, conservation and heritage area.

Often internship roles are defined by organisations in need of content writing, archiving, and researching.

Formally, an internship of 6-8 weeks could gain 2 Internship Credits.

Such credits will be mentored and monitored by a Visual Arts Faculty and will be mapped by the concerned mentor.

All internships, like ISM, will be mapped prior to the placements.

Students are expected to reach out to individual organisations on their own for internship opportunities. The department of Visual Arts does not take responsibility for internship placements of individual students. However, some information and references can be facilitated on an individual basis.

Students pursuing VA Minor can apply for summer and winter internships in the following organisations, apart from individual artists' studios or with individual art scholars and researchers. Following organisations are recommended but this list is only a suggestive list.

- Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, Noida and Saket, Delhi
- Jehangir Nicholson Foundation, CSMVS, Mumbai.
- JD Centre of Art Bhubaneswar.
- Museum of Art and Photography, Bangalore.
- Asia Art Archive in India, New Delhi.
- Foundation for Indian Contemporary Art, New Delhi.
- Delhi Art Gallery, New Delhi

Frequently Asked Questions

- a. What are the mandatory courses to complete a minor in Visual Arts?

For UG 2022 onwards, the four mandatory courses are

1. Histories of South Asian Art offered by Sraman Mukerjee
2. Sites and Sights offered by Sraman Mukerjee
3. Arts of our Times I offered by Rakhi Peswani (offered by Sreejata Roy in Academic Year 2024-25)
4. Arts of Our Times II offered by Rakhi Peswani (offered by Sreejata Roy in Academic Year 2024-25)

- b. What are the mandatory courses to complete a Concentration in Visual Arts?

For UG 2022 onwards, the four mandatory courses are:

1. Histories of South Asian Art offered by Sraman Mukerjee
2. Sites and Sights offered by Sraman Mukerjee
3. Arts of our Times I offered by Sreejata Roy (in Academic Year 2024-25)
4. Arts of Our Times II offered by Sreejata Roy (in Academic Year 2024-25)

- c. Do any courses have any prerequisites?

Unless mentioned, most courses offered by the Department do not have prerequisites.

- d. Are courses to be taken in the order of levels (1000, 2000, 3000)?

It is not a mandatory requirement, but taking courses in the increasing order of levels is encouraged for the benefit of the students.

Studio Guidelines

1. The studio is open for public use only between 10am - 6pm from Monday to Friday. The Studio is closed on Saturday & Sundays. If students want to access the studio outside the designated hours they can write to the studio manager with their request at least 24 hours prior to when they want to use the studio.
2. The studio cannot be accessed by the public during class hours – 3:00-6:00 on Tuesday and Thursday and 6:30 - 8:30pm on Wednesday.
3. All studio facilities consumable and non-consumable materials, including but not restricted to all electronic equipment, cameras, tripods, drawing tablets, are solely meant for use of Visual Arts courses, including Visual Arts courses cross-listed with other Departments. No unsupervised use of any materials, including but not limited to electronic equipment, are permitted. The Studio Manager, and in certain cases and relevant course instructors, can check out these materials for courses only. The Studio Manager is the primary supervisor of studio equipment, and materials, including but not limited to electronic equipment.
4. Studio does not allow unsupervised use of Studio space and materials.
5. Only in certain courses, and in exceptional circumstances, students can gain permission to check out and check in all the materials they are by using in a register kept with the Studio Manager. Any damage to the materials, during unsupervised use, will have to be compensated by the student who is responsible for the same.
6. The clay in the studio is primarily intended for the students enrolled in Visual Arts Courses. If students who are not enrolled in the same courses want to make use of the clay then they need to take the permission of both the studio manager and the Head of the Department.
7. The studio provides the following materials to students (enrolled in VA courses + rest of the students)- drawing boards, easels, stools, printmaking press, glass table for printmaking, Intaglio ink, pottery wheels, carving tools and ceramic tools, cutting mats, paper cutting knives, metal scales, measuring tapes, and masking tape.
8. Students will have to get their own paper, paints, paintbrushes, stationary, and printmaking blocks (wood/lino) and tools for use in the studio.
9. It is important to not leave materials lying around the studio and to keep the studio clean. Make sure you're responsible for your own space and that you don't damage others' artwork kept in the studio.

Any VISUAL ARTS STUDIO queries must be directed to our Studio Manager,

Mr. Anuj Kumar Yadav

Email- anuj.yadav@ashoka.edu.in

Course Catalogue

Gateway Courses offered by the Department across Monsoon and Spring semesters

Monsoon Semester (2024-25)

Gateway courses:

VA-2004: Arts of Our Times I

Instructor: Rakhi Peswani, for Monsoon 2024, Sreejata Roy (sreejata.roy@ashoka.edu.in)

Course Level: 1000-2000 Gateway course

Course Prerequisites for students (if any): No pre-requisites

Schedule: Thursday - 3:10-6:20pm

Course Description:

This course will enable the fundamentals of contemporary artistic practices through the structures of Materiality, Representation, Space, Place, Time and (Im)materiality. Students will be urged to develop questions and expressions through a basis in practice of visual and other media forms. The course will engage experimentation in 2 Dimensional, 3 Dimensional and time-based media to arrive at ideas and concepts through formations of repetitions.

Framework and Objectives:

The objective of this course is to enable students with foundational clarity in contemporary artistic practices and its possibilities. The course is designed to provide students certain potentiality in observing or asking difficult/complex concerns or reflections with and through varying media of artistic practices.

The course will be based on certain guidelines of media specificity and expansion of concepts/messages through medium.

Since it is a studio-based course, certain introductions to histories of abstraction and installation art will be provided through the framework of revisionist art practices after the 1960s as well as provide introductions to affective possibilities of artistic languages. Both these realms will be expanded through making of artistic form and references towards art practices.

The overarching objective of the course is to provide students with faith and confidence in visual/aural/verbal languages that amalgamate other sense perceptions and to provide a certain foundational understanding of language and affect in artistic forms.

Since it is a studio-based course, certain introductions to histories of abstraction and installation art will be provided through the framework of revisionist art practices after the 1960s as well as provide introductions to affective possibilities of artistic languages. Both these realms will be expanded through making of artistic form and references towards art practices.

Details of Course modules along with readings for every module:

This course will introduce fundamentals of contemporary artistic practices through the structures of Time, Space/Place and (Im)materiality. Students will be urged to develop questions and expressions through a basis in practice of various media forms to address notions of Time, Space, Materiality. The course will engage experimentation in 2-Dimensional, 3-Dimensional and time-based media to develop concepts.

The objective of this course is to instil confidence in students and inculcate foundational clarity in contemporary artistic practices, its possibilities.

Since it is a studio-based course, certain introductions to histories of abstraction and installation art will be provided through the framework of revisionist art practices after the 1960s as well as provide introductions to affective possibilities of artistic languages. Both these realms will be expanded through making of artistic form and references towards art practices.

Various modules that will be expanded:

- Image and idea. Image as a form. Visual and literary image.
- Image construction through Lines, Hues, Colours, Shapes, Forms etc.
- Image and Drawing, Drawing and time; Drawing as an object in space.
- Painting, in time and space. Painting as a process.
- Photography and time. Photography as image
- 3-dimensional media and relationship with time and space.

Deliverables:

The requirement of the course is to articulate experiences and concerns beyond the spoken or written words and to develop a line of enquiry through visual/media forms.

1. The course must culminate with handing over a series of works (drawings/painting/photographs/sculpture/sound/video) with 2-3 media forms that helps a student articulate and express certain specific areas of concern.
2. A proposal for a site specific sculptural intervention with structured concepts, clay maketts, drawings, photographs, scaled details.
3. A written essay about the visual/media work completed during the coursework, with reflection on the images created, discoveries during the processes and the outcome of the course work.

Attendance/ Participation Policy for students:

90% attendance (2 absences allowed without question)

Histories of South Asian Art: From the Earliest Times to the Present
Monsoon Semester 2024

Course Instructor: Sraman Mukherjee (sraman.mukherjee@ashoka.edu.in)

Course Code: VA-3006/ HIS-3804-1

Course Level: Level 1000 to 2000 for Visual Arts and 3000 for History (Gateway course for Visual Arts and Elective Course for History)

Pre-Requisites: None

Schedule: Mondays and Wednesdays, 10:10 am to 11:40 am

Office Hours: Mondays, 1:30 am to 2:30 pm (IST), or by prior email appointment of at least 48 hours ahead

Office AC 02 311/02

No prior training in Visual Arts or Art History required.

The course is a gateway (core) course in Visual Arts Minor/ Concentration and is open for credit and audit by students across all disciplines and Departments.

Course Description

What is Art and who is it meant for? What is specifically South Asian about South Asian Art? What does it mean to think of South Asia and Art as analytical categories? Did South Asian Art always exist? Or were historical processes involved in the making of the field? Where do we locate the “genesis” of art in South Asia? Did art forms in South Asia emerge in a zone of cultural and social isolation? Or can we trace trajectories of trans-regional contacts, encounters, and exchanges as central to the shaping of the field of South Asian Art? What is space of tradition and innovation in the visual arts of South Asia? Did arts of South Asia “influence” artistic practices in other regions? How did artists at different points in history think about the region we identify as South Asia? Seeking to address some of these questions, this course examines aspects of the visual arts of South Asia from its earliest traces in cave paintings and stone implements to sculpture, painting, illustrated manuscripts, calligraphy, and architecture. The course follows a chronological scale, from prehistory to c. 1980s.

The vast geographical as well as the temporal span of the field will restrict the course from delivering an encyclopaedic survey. The course will prioritize intensive analysis of selected themes. Rather than placing the teleology of South Asian “art” solely in the context of changing dynastic histories, the course takes up specific themes in art across a range of objects, artefacts, archaeological sites, built spaces, religious and political symbols, and institutions of art pedagogy and exhibitions. In the process we address the questions of image, icon, and representations of body, portraiture, architectural forms, landscape, in the context of social and ideological changes, aesthetic turns, shifting patrons and markets, and introduction of new material media. The course will probe both ‘South Asia’ and ‘South Asian Art’ as stable (art) historical categories and map the new methodologies and vocabularies employed by art historians.

Class discussions will form the basis for compulsory museum/ gallery/ site classes to the National Museum of India (New Delhi, contingent on the continuity of the existing institution, physical classes), NGMA (New Delhi, physical classes), Delhi Art Gallery (Delhi, physical classes), National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum (New Delhi, physical classes), Indian Museum, Kolkata (Virtual), British Museum (Virtual), Victoria and Albert Museum (Virtual) and the MET (Virtual) which will enable us to study the works of art in their institutional locations and explore the visual dynamics of organization of exhibition spaces.

Modules to be expanded in the Course:

Introduction: Interrogating South Asia: Visualizing a “region”

Module # 1 Art and the Ritual Lives of South Asian Images

Module # 2 Locating "Art"? Material Traces of the Earliest Civilizations

Module # 3 Buddhism and Early Indian Visual Narrative

Module# 4 Stylistic Influences and Material Media of Sculptural Art: Art History and Historiography

Module#5 Art as Cultural Index: The shifting landscape of Indic Art

Module#6 Placing South Asian Art and Material Culture in the Cultural Context of the Galleries, Museums, Sites – compulsory museum/ gallery/ site classes to the National Museum of India (New Delhi, contingent on the continuity of the existing institution, physical classes), NGMA (New Delhi, physical classes), Delhi Art Gallery (Delhi, physical classes), National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum (New Delhi, physical classes), Indian Museum, Kolkata (Virtual), British Museum (Virtual), Victoria and Albert Museum (Virtual) and the MET (Virtual). The physical visits are planned across the entire semester on 2 Saturdays.

Module#7 Translations in Contact Zones: Sites and Objects

Modules#8 and 9 Art of the Court

Module#10 Imperial Encounters: Representing the Colonial Space

Module#11 Designing the Nation: “Art” and its “Popular others”

Module#12 Art and Decolonization: Reflections on South Asia’s Artistic Modernisms

Module# 13 Notes on "South Asian Contemporary"

Select Readings:

Mohammad-Arif, Aminah. “Introduction. Imaginations and Constructions of South Asia: An Enchanting Abstraction?”, *SAMAJ*, 10, 2014, 1-27

Asher, Frederick M. "Historiography of South Asian Art", *Oxford Bibliographies* (DOI: 10.1093/OBO/9780199920105-0010)

Davis, Richard. "Loss and Recovery of Ritual Self among Hindu Images", *Journal of Ritual Studies*, Vol. 6, No. 1, 1992, 43-61

Neumayer, Erwin. "Bodies in Motion", *Archaeology*, Vol. 50, No. 1, 1997, 56-59.

Lee, Sherman E. *History of Far Eastern Art*. New Jersey: Prentice Hall, 1994 (selections)

Mitter, Partha. *Indian Art*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2001

Chakrabarti, Dilip K. *India, An Archaeological History: Palaeolithic Beginnings to Early Historic Foundations*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1999, 2010

Dehejia, Vidya. "On Modes of Visual Narration in Early Buddhist Art", *The Art Bulletin*, Vol. 72, No. 3 (September, 1990), pp. 374-392

Asher, Frederick and Walter Spink, "Mauryan Figural Sculpture Reconsidered." *Ars Orientalis*, 19, 1989

Abe, Stanley K. "Inside the Wonder House: Buddhist Art and the West", in Donald S. Lopez Jr., ed. *Curators of the Buddha: The Study of Buddhism under Colonialism*. Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1995

Asher, Frederick M. *The Art of Eastern India, 300-800*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1980 (selections)

Singh, Upinder and Parul Pandya Dhar, eds. *Asian Encounters: Exploring Connected Histories*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2014 (selections)

Flood, Finbarr B. *Objects of Translation: Material Culture and Medieval "Hindu-Muslim" Encounter*. Princeton and Oxford: Princeton University Press, 2009. (selections TBA)

Eaton, Richard M. and Phillip B. Wagoner, *Power, Memory, Architecture: Contested Sites on India's Deccan Plateau, 1300-1600*. Oxford University Press, 2014

Singh, Kavita. *Real Birds in Imagined Gardens: Mughal Painting between Asia and Europe*. Getty Research Institute, 2017

Asher, Catherine B. *Architecture of Mughal India* (New Cambridge History of India I:4). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992

Asher, Catherine B. and Cynthia Talbot, eds. *India Before Europe*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.

Tillotson, G. H. R. "The Indian Travels of William Hodges", *Journal of the Royal Asiatic Society*, Third Series, Vol. 2, No. 3, 1992, 377-398.

Pelizzari, Maria Antonella. *Traces of India: Photography, Architecture, and the Politics of Representation, 1850-1900*. Canadian Centre for Architecture, 2003

Guha-Thakurta, Tapati. *The Making of a New 'Indian' Art: Artists, Aesthetics and Nationalism in Bengal c.1850-1920*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992, 46–184.

Ramaswamy, Sumathi. “Body Politic(s): Maps and Mother Goddesses in Modern India” in Richard Davis ed. *Picturing the Nation: Iconographies of Modern India*. Orient Longman, 2007, 32 – 50.

Mitter, Partha. *Art and Nationalism in Colonial India 1850-1922*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992.

Pinney, Christopher. *‘Photos of the Gods’: The Printed Image and Political Struggle in India*. London: Reaktion, 2004

Mitter, Partha. *The Triumph of Modernism: India’s artists and the avant-garde 1922-1947*. London: Reaktion Books, 2007 (selections)

Brown, Rebecca M. "A Distant Contemporary: Indian Twentieth-Century Art in the Festival of India", *The Art Bulletin*, 2014, 96:3, 338-356

Learning Outcomes:

On successful completion of the course, we will be able to:

- a) Identify and analyse aspects of works of art and visual images in different material and medium using appropriate vocabulary
- b) Explore the main trends in the development of Art History and Visual Culture by accessing the critical essential skills
- c) Evaluate the approaches of artists, art historians, visual anthropologists and curators to the field of visual arts
- d) Develop the interests for a future training in critical art historical training and art curatorial programmes

Grading Rubric:

This course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading through the entire semester including active class and online museum visits and image analysis, and mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading criterion are as follows:

1. Students will be assessed on the basis of their active engagement with course contents during classes and after class office hours which will carry ten percent (10%) of the total course grades.

2. Museum, gallery and site classes and image analysis will carry thirty percent (30%) of the total course grades. The subsequent submission of a written report on an object/ image of your choice (within a word limit of 700 to 900 words) counts for 30% of the total course grades.
3. The mid semester assessment will consist of a class presentation based on any one image chosen by the student in discussion with the instructor. The mid semester evaluation will carry twenty percent (20%) of the total course grades.
4. For the end semester evaluation, we will write an essay between 2000 and 2500 words (including footnotes and bibliography). The topic of the end semester assessment has to be chosen by the student from a range of verbal text and visual image prompts provided by the course instructor. The end semester assessments for this course will follow a feed forward method and students are actively encouraged to submit (within date and time specified) one working draft/ draft in progress to the course instructor for comments and feedback. The end semester assessment will carry forty percent (40%) of the total course grades.
5. Audit students have to give and actively participate in classes (both on campus and museum, gallery, and site classes). Students auditing the course have to present for the mid semester presentations. For end semester assessments, audit students have to submit 250-400 words abstracts of the end semester essay. Attendance and Class participation for audit students are the same as credit students.
6. All submissions including gallery/ museum/ site reports, mid semester and end semester papers must be made electronically (over Ashoka email id) to the course instructor.
7. Plagiarism (intended or unintended) constitutes the most serious academic offence. Any act of plagiarism will be reported to the Academic Integrity Committee of the University and will attract punitive measures from grade cuts to failing the course. The first detection of plagiarism in any paper will result in grade cuts and reporting to the AIC. For repeat offense, students will be allotted a Fail grade for the entire course. Please go through the Academic Integrity document of Ashoka University to check what constitutes plagiarism and other forms of academic dishonesty. Specific citation styles for texts and images will be addressed by specific course instructors.

Attendance Policy:

Up to 3 undocumented absences are permitted for the entire semester for credit and audit students. Gallery/ Museum/ Site classes are compulsory for both credit and audit students.

Gateway courses: Spring Semester 2025

VA-3054: Arts of Our Times II - Media as Material of Practice

Instructor: Rakhi Peswani, for Spring 2025, Sreejata Roy

Course Level: Level 1000/2000 Gateway course

Course Prerequisites for students (if any): Recommended course as prerequisite (not mandatory) Arts of Our Times I: Mediums and Media in Contemporary

Schedule : To be announced

Course Description:

This course will enable students to inculcate fundamentals of contemporary artistic practice through material or immaterial interventions within certain critical contexts of their choice. Students will be urged to develop questions and expressions through a basis in non-functional or fictional routes, basing their work in visual and/or other media forms. Students will be urged to produce a line of enquiry as an expression, in the formation of drawings, journaling, published material/blogs or any kind of public exposition of their ideas. Social/cultural contexts will be seen as terrains that enable artistic concerns through creative questions. Channels for information and communication will be seen as possible mediums to investigate and experiment in creation of artistic practices. 2 Dimensional, 3 Dimensional, time based media and other media forms will be explored to locate contexts of location and circulation. Arts will be seen as a possible critical tool of communication, through interventions, provocations, positions, and reflections in social/political contexts.

Added Bibliography and further references:

Valentino Catricala (edt) (2015) - Media Art- Towards a new Definition of Arts in the Age of Technology

Petra Lange-Berndt (edt) (2015) (The MIT press)- Materiality Documents of Contemporary Art

Grading Rubric:

- Cumulative grading through three assignments over the semester.
- Each assignment will have components of creative practice based on a public communication/intervention of work/ideas.
- Each assignment will be based on inter-media practices, which may be specific to chosen contexts. Writing, photographic visuals, interventions, essay, print media, or any other form of media may be chosen. The efficacy of each assignment will be to create a project based engagement and framework of public exchange/communication/participation.
- Each assignment will have modules of contexts, technique and practice-oriented work.

The grading rubrics will be:

75% Practice:

(25% Location of context. Creation of frameworks.

20% Critical and Thematic concerns.

30% Implementation of ideas/interventions/communication.)

25% Class participation

Learning outcomes:

- To enable critical artistic practices outside the confines of studio-based enquiry. Enable a framework of practice that considers media as an amalgamation of social, political, cultural / aesthetic contexts and as a potential tool of creative and critical thinking.
- To enable articulation of critical concerns through creativity and artistic continuities.

Attendance/ Participation policy for students:

Up to 3 unannounced absences through the entire semester is permitted.

Sites and Sights: Museums, Exhibitions and the Making of the Art

Course Instructor: Sraman Mukherjee (sraman.mukherjee@ashoka.edu.in)

Course Code: VA-2005/ HIS-3802/ SOA-2225-1

Course Level: 2000 to 3000 for Visual Arts and Sociology, Anthropology, and 3000 for History

Gateway/ Compulsory course for Visual Arts Minor or Concentration and Elective course for History.

Course also open for credit and audit by students from any other department/ discipline

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: To be declared

Course Description:

How do sites and spaces of visual encounters condition our perceptions of visual images? This course brings in dialogue works of art with the spaces that such works have come to inhabit in our present world – museums, art galleries, and other spaces of visual exhibitions. Moving beyond the established trajectories of looking at exhibitions, museums, and gallery spaces as storehouses of masterpieces of Art, or merely as spaces of ordering, classifying, and displaying

objects and images, we will look closely at how exhibition practices of museums and public art galleries, constitute the very category “Art” around a select body of objects and images.

Beginning with early modern royal and notable private collections, and cabinet of curiosities across the world, the course will explore the specific moments of the coming into being of public museums and art galleries through fairs, “freak shows”, and world exhibitions in Europe and across different parts of the world. It will explore how politics of collection, museum acquisition, display, and repatriation are tied with larger questions of colonialism, war, loot, postcolonial nationalist reassertions, and postwar encounters with race and ethnicity. With a specific focus on Asia, the course will map the connected global trajectories of museums, art galleries and memorials as dense narratives of unfolding spatial and temporal complexes. In the process it will highlight the role of the artists, curators, and museum/ gallery visitors in the production of a complex set of dialogues around artistic, and curatorial visions. The course will end by looking at contemporary South Asia, mapping the challenges of redesigning exhibition orders of older museums and art institutions and spread of museum modes of display and viewing, with different intent, in commemorative sites, theme parks, memorials, and new temples.

This co-constitution of art and art museums will be addressed during class discussions and during museum, gallery and site classes (both physical and virtual) to local galleries, museums, theme parks, and temples – to the Indian Museum, Kolkata (virtual), the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi (on site), the National Museum, New Delhi (on site,) the National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum, New Delhi, (on site), the Rashtriya Dalit Prerna Sthal, Nodia (on site), the Swaminarayan Akshardham Complex, New Delhi (on site). Bhai Mati Das Museum (New Delhi), the British Museum, London (virtual) and the Victoria and Albert Museum, London (virtual).

Modules to be expanded further in the Course:

Introduction: Why Museums? Rethinking Exhibitions as Plural visions in space and time

Module 1: Paths Taken and Forgotten: From Cabinet of Curiosities, Freak Shows, and Circus to the “Exhibitionary Complex” of early International Exhibitions and Public Museums

Module 2: Displaying/ Representing The “Others” in the “First Cities” of the Empires
Module 3 Beyond Magic: Museums as Transmutations: Colonial Locations of Imperial Material Archives

Module 4: Postcolonial Passages, Museums in Postcolonial States

Module 5: Memories/ Memorials, Museums as Sites

Module 6: The Spill over: Temples, Theme Parks and Museums

Module 7: Compulsory Museum, Gallery and Site Classes (off campus onsite and virtual) Site Classes in select galleries of the Indian Museum, Kolkata (virtual), the National Gallery of Modern Art, New Delhi (physical/ on site), the National Museum (physical/ on site), the National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum, New Delhi (physical/ on site), the Rashtriya Dalit Prerna Sthal, Nodia (Physical), the Swaminarayan Akshardham Complex (physical/ on site), Bhai Mati Das Museum New Delhi (Physical/ on site), the British Museum (virtual), and the Victoria and Albert Museum, London (virtual). The off campus compulsory museum gallery and site classes would be conducted across 2 Saturdays throughout the entire semester.

Module 8: Decolonizing Museums? Rethinking “Exhibitionary Complex” as Multiple Temporalities

Select Readings:

Duncan, Carol. *Civilising Rituals: Inside Public Art Museums*. London: Routledge, 1996. (Chapter 2)

Bennett, Tony. *The Birth of the Museum: History, Theory, Politics*. London: Routledge, 1995. (Chapter 5- The Exhibitionary Complex)

Willis, Deborah. *The Black Venus 2010: They Called Her “Hottentot”*. Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 2010 (Chapter 14)

Mitchell, Timothy. “The World as Exhibition”, *Comparative Studies in History and Society*, vol. 31, no. 9, 1989.

Mathur, Saloni. *India by Design: Colonial History and Cultural Display*. University of California Press, 2007 (chapter 2)

Breckenridge, Carol A. “The Aesthetics and Politics of Colonial Collecting: India at World Fairs”, *Comparative Studies in Society and History*, 31/2, 1989, 195-216

Guha-Thakurta, Tapati. *Monuments, Objects, Histories: Institutions of Art in Colonial and Postcolonial India*. New York: Columbia University Press, 2004 (Chapter 2)

Codell, Julie F. “Ironies of Mimicry: The Art of Sayaji Rao III Gaekwad, Maharaja of Baroda, and the Cultural Politics of Early Modern India”, *Journal of History of Collections*, 15/5, 2003, 127-146.

Prakash, Gyan. “Science ‘Gone Native’ in Colonial India.” *Representations*, 40, Fall 1992, 153-178

Singh, Kavita. “The Museum is National” in Saloni Mathur and Kavita Singh eds. *No Touching, No Spitting, No Praying*. New Delhi: Routledge, 2015, 107-131

- Bhatti, Shaila. *Translating Museums: A Counter History of South Asian Museology*. London and New York: Routledge, 2012, 2016 (Selections)
- Harris, Clare. "The Potala Palace: Remembering to Forget in Contemporary Tibet", *South Asian Studies*, 2013, 29:1, 61-75
- Fangquing Lu. "Museum architecture as spatial storytelling of historical time: Manifesting a primary example of Jewish space in Yad Vashem Holocaust History Museum", *Frontiers of Architectural Research*, 6, 2017, 442-455
- Nora, Pierre. "Between Memory and History: Les Lieux de Mémoire", *Representations*, 26, Spring, 1989, 7-24
- Mathur, Saloni and Kavita Singh. "Reincarnations of the Museum: The Museum in an Age of Religious Revivalism" in Saloni Mathur and Kavita Singh eds. *No Touching, No Spitting, No Praying*. New Delhi: Routledge, 2015, 203-218.
- Jain, Kajri. "The Hand Bag That Exploded: Mayawati's Monuments and the Aesthetics of Democracy in Post Reform India", in Partha Chatterjee, Tapati Guha-Thakurta, and Bodhisattva Kar, ed. *New Cultural Histories of India: Materiality and Practices*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2014 (Chapter 5)
- Jain, Kajri. "Post-reform India's automotive-iconic-cement assemblages: uneven globality, territorial spectacle and iconic exhibition value", *Identities: Global Studies in Culture and Power*, 2015, 1-18.
- Brown, Rebecca. *Displaying Time: The Many Temporalities of the Festival of India*. Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2017 (Selections)
- Bharucha, Rustom. "Beyond the box", *Third Text*, 14:52, 2000, 11-19

Learning Outcomes:

On successful completion of the course, we will be able to:

- Explore the main trends in the development of Art History, Visual Culture and Museum Studies by accessing the critical essential skills.
- Evaluate the approaches of artists, art historians, and curators to the field of visual arts and museum studies
- Explore curatorial practices in the art world
- Develop the interests for future training in art curatorial programmes and critical museum studies.

Grading Rubric:

This course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading through the entire semester including active class participation, museum and gallery visits, and mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading criterion are as follows:

- Students will be assessed on the basis of their active engagement with course contents during classes which will carry ten percent (10%) of the total course grades.

2) Museum, Gallery and site visits and subsequent submission of one written report on spatial politics gallery display, curatorial visions, and visitor perceptions (within 800 to 1000 words) will carry thirty percent (30%) of the total course grades.

3) The mid semester assessment will consist of a class presentation based on any one site or gallery or an image in a museum chosen by the student in consultation with the instructor. The mid semester evaluation will carry twenty percent (20%) of the total course grades.

1. For the end semester evaluation, we will write an essay between 2000 and 2500 words (including footnotes and bibliography). The topic of the end semester assessment has to be chosen by the student from a range of verbal text and visual image prompts provided by the course instructor. The end semester assessments for this course will follow a feed forward method and students are actively encouraged to submit (within date and time specified) one working draft/ draft in progress to the course instructor for comments and feedback. The end semester assessment will carry forty percent (40%) of the total course grades.

2. All submissions including field reports, mid semester and end semester papers have to be made electronically.

3. Plagiarism (intended or unintended) constitutes the most serious academic offence. Any act of plagiarism will be reported to the Academic Integrity Committee of the University and will attract punitive measures from grade cuts to failing the course. Please go through the Academic Integrity document of Ashoka University to check what constitutes plagiarism and other forms of academic dishonesty. Specific citation styles for texts and images will be addressed by specific course instructors.

MONSOON 2024

Elective courses:

Empire, Nation, and Art: Histories from the Visual Image

Course Instructor: Sraman Mukherjee (sraman.mukherjee@ashoka.edu.in)

Course Code: VA-3002/ HIS-3801-1

Course Level: 2000 for Visual Arts, 3000 for History

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: Classes Mondays and Wednesdays, 11:50 am to 1:20 pm

Office Hours: Wednesdays 1:30 pm to 2:30 pm or on mutually available schedule fixed by prior appointments over email (at least 48 hours prior notification)

No prior training in Visual Arts or Art History required.

The course is an elective course in Visual Arts and is cross listed with History as an elective course. The course is open for credit and audit by students across all Disciplines and Departments.

Monsoon Semester 2024

Course Description:

This course explores global social formations from the fifteenth century of the Common Era to our present times through the prism of visual images. We specifically focus on the centrality of visual archives in mapping histories of European colonialism under Spanish, Portuguese, Dutch, French, and British empires. The course will address a range of colonial formations and diverse articulations of nationalist thought and consciousness in different parts of the world through different visual forms across a range of media, sites, and objects. Beginning from naturalist paintings and drawings of unknown landscapes and oceans, descriptions of plants and animals, of unknown humans and exotic objects, the course moves on to explore diverse media and technologies of visual (re)productions like water colour, oil painting, lithographs, oleographs, chromolithographs, aquatints, photographs and the moving image, and maps different sites of visual simulations like cabinet de curiosities, ‘freak shows’, world exhibitions, metropolitan, colonial, and postcolonial public museums, art galleries, institutes of fine arts, crafts and design pedagogy. The course argues that global histories of colonialism, nationalism, and decolonization can be partially explored as histories of encounters, violent conflicts, tortuous negotiations, and often uneasy accommodations played out at the register of the visual image. The course urges us to rethink that the notions of metropolis and colony, empire and nation, colonizer and colonized, alien and indigenous, as they are configured and reconfigured in the archives of the visual image, are historically relative, often fluid categories, having only situational relevance. Moving away from a purely Euro-centric discussion of the beginnings of Art and Art History, this course seeks to move towards a global history of art.

Class discussions will form the basis for compulsory museum/ gallery/ site classes to the National Museum of India, New Delhi, (physical class), NGMA (New Delhi, physical class), Delhi Art Gallery (Delhi, physical class), National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum (New Delhi, physical class), Indian Museum, Kolkata (Virtual), British Museum (Virtual), Victoria and Albert Museum (Virtual) and the MET (Virtual) which will enable us to study the works of art in their institutional locations and explore the visual dynamics of organization of exhibition spaces. The gallery, museum and site classes are organized on Saturdays, mutually convenient for the instructor and the students.

Modules to be expanded further in the Course:

- A. Globes and the Maps
- B. Colonizing the Natural World
- C. Colour and Empires: Image productions, reproduction, circulation and consumption
- D. The Photographic and Moving Images
- E. Viewing/ Thinking from the Postcolonial locations

Select Readings:

Benjamin Schmidt, “Mapping an Exotic World: The Global Project of Dutch Cartography, circa 1700”, in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Nicholas Thomas, “Objects of Knowledge: Oceanic Artifacts in European Engravings” in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Terry Smith, “Visual Regimes of Colonization: European and Aboriginal Seeing in Australia”, in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Sumathi Ramaswamy, *Terrestrial Lessons: The Conquest of the World as Globe*. (Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 2017) (Selections to be announced)

Daniela Bleichmar, “Painting as Exploration: Visualizing Nature in Eighteenth-Century Colonial Science”, in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Serge Gruzinski, “The Walls of Images”, in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Natasha Eaton, “Excess in the City? The Consumption of Imported Prints in Colonial Calcutta, c. 1780–c. 1795” in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014).

Natasha Eaton, *Colour, Art and Empire: Visual Culture and the Nomadism of Representation* (London: I. B. Tauris, 2013) (selections to be announced)

David Ciarlo, “Advertising and the Optics of Colonial Power at the Fin de Siecle” in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014).

Christopher Pinney and Nicholas Peterson, ed, *Photography's Other Histories* (Duke University Press, 2003) (Selections)

James L. Hevia, "The Photography Complex: Exposing Boxer-Era China (1900–1901), Making Civilization" in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Brian Larkin, "Colonialism and the Built Space of Cinema", in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Zeynep Celik, "Speaking Back to Orientalist Discourse", in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Krista A. Thompson, "I Am Rendered Speechless by Your Idea Of Beauty": The Picturesque in History and Art in the Postcolony, in Martin Jay and Sumathi Ramaswamy, ed. *Empires of Vision: A Reader* (Durham and London, Duke University Press, 2014)

Iftikhar Dadi, *Modernism and the Art of Muslim South Asia* (Chapel Hill: The University of North Carolina Press, 2010) (selections to be announced)

Grading Rubric:

This course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading through the entire semester including active class and site visit participation, and mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading criterion are as follows:

1) Students will be assessed based on their active engagement with course contents which will carry ten percent (10%) of the total course grades.

2) The mid semester assessment will consist of a class presentation of an essay based on images chosen by the student in consultation with the instructor. The mid semester evaluation will carry 40% of the total course grades.

3) For the end semester evaluation candidates are required to write an essay between 2000 and 2500 words (including footnotes and bibliography). The topic of the end semester assessment has to be decided by the student in conjunction with the course instructor. The end semester assessments for this course will follow a feed forward method and students are actively encouraged to submit (within date and time specified) 1 or 2 working drafts/ drafts in progress to the course instructor for comments and feedback. The end semester assessment will carry 50% of the total course grades.

4) All submissions including mid semester presentation ppts and end semester essays must be made electronically (over Ashoka email id) to the course instructor.

5) Audit students have to give and actively participate in classes (both on campus and museum, gallery, and site classes). Students auditing the course have to present for the mid semester presentations. For end semester assessments, audit students have to submit 250-400 words

abstracts of the end semester essay. Attendance and Class participation for audit students are the same as credit students.

6) Plagiarism (intended or unintended) constitutes the most serious academic offence. Any act of plagiarism will be reported to the Academic Integrity Committee of the University and will attract punitive measures from grade cuts to failing the course. The first detection of plagiarism in any paper will result in grade cuts and reporting to the AIC. For repeat offense, students will be allotted a Fail grade for the entire course. Please go through the Academic Integrity document of Ashoka University to check what constitutes plagiarism and other forms of academic dishonesty. Specific citation styles for texts and images will be addressed by specific course instructors.

Learning Outcomes:

On successful completion of the course, we will be able to:

- a) Identify and analyse aspects of works of art and visual images in different materials and media using appropriate vocabulary.
- b) Explore the main trends in the development of Art History and Visual Culture by accessing the critical essential skills.
- c) Evaluate the approaches of artists, art historians, visual anthropologists and curators to the field of visual arts.
- d) Develop the interests for a future training in critical art historical training and art curatorial program.

Attendance Policy:

Three undocumented absences are permitted for the entire semester. The museum and gallery classes will be conducted across 2 Saturdays in the entire semester and are compulsory attendance for credit and audit students.

Visual Culture of Indian Paintings: Courtly Traditions

Course Instructor: Priyani Roy Choudhury

Course Code: VA VA 2001/ HIS 3806

Course Level: 2000 for Visual Arts, 3000 for History

Course Prerequisite: None

Attendance Policy: None

Schedule: Tue, Thu. 10:10-11:40 am

Course Description:

This course offers a critical survey of paintings made for Mughal, Rajput and Deccani courts in India. While the primary focus will be on the period between the 16th and 18th centuries, the course will also explore the sources of these courtly traditions within Persian and Indian schools of

paintings on the one hand, as well as their influence beyond the eighteenth century. The course will open ways of entering the intensely visual fields of these paintings for students. It will map the field by exploring schools, workshops and ateliers and offer an understanding of style as a dynamic tool, both for artists and patrons. Following this, the course will focus on themes both as subject matter of the paintings, and for understanding the affective, cultural and political value of these works. Themes will include the relationship of texts and paintings, representation of music, devotion, and courtly etiquette.

Modules:

Introduction: Rethinking our approaches to cultural pasts

This introductory lecture will provide a brief overview of the course content. We will briefly discuss categories such as 'Islamic,' Persian', 'Mughal', 'pre-Mughal' and 'Sultanate,' and critically examine the impact of such categorizations on the discipline of art history. We will also discuss approaches to visual studies which will help us navigate the course and initiate reflections on the mobility of materials, objects, visual tropes, and people, highlighting both continuities and divergences in the production of art.

Module 1: The Arts of the book in South Asia at the beginning of the 16th century: Legacies, transitions, and multiplicities.

The module traces the development of the 'Western Indian Style' of painting, focusing on Gujarat-Rajasthan, Delhi, Gwalior, Malwa, and Jaunpur. It will also reference Turco-Mongol painting traditions of Iran, Central Asia, the rise of the Timurids and the impact of major literary works such as the Shahnama, and the Khamsa of Nizami on the arts of India. A key theme will be the production, translation, and circulation of knowledge that fostered dialogues between different communities.

Module 2: Cross-cultural currents in the 16th Century: The transformative aesthetics of new empires.

This module focuses on new artistic energies in the Deccan and North India; it examines style as a conduit in which aesthetic and political considerations are intertwined. It is contextualized by the new global order of the 16th century: marked by direct sea routes between Europe and the rise of "Gunpowder Empires", and the transformative speed of aesthetic exchange. With this backdrop, the module will look at the beginnings of new centres of art in the Deccan and the foundations of the Mughal atelier by concentrating on some of the remarkable manuscripts produced in Deccani and Mughal courts in the 1570s.

Module 3: Inscribing the Dynasty and the Sovereign: The Emperor and the Rebel

Between 1580s and 1605, manuscript production under Akbar was marked by conscious, deliberate constructions of visual and written chronicles of the dynasty, the emperor and the production and dissemination of knowledge. We will explore the significant role played by artists of the Mughal atelier in the process of constructing "style", the relationship between text and imagery, the deliberate visual choices, and the use of allegory in the representation of dynastic power and sovereignty. The last section of the module will explore the works created in Prince Salim's studio in Allahabad during his rebellion against Akbar. We examine the significance of a

rebel prince patronizing painting, and the counter movements set up vis-a-vis Akbar's atelier as a statement of an alternate centre of power.

Module 4: Translation Projects under the Mughals: Their production, circulation and dissemination of Mughal styles outside the imperium.

In 1574, Akbar initiated ambitious translation endeavours, notably commissioning translations of the *Mahabharata* (known as *Razmnama*) and the *Ramayana*. This initiative gained momentum alongside Akbar's expanding religious tolerance and the arrival of the first Jesuit Mission from Goa. Additionally prominent figures like Akbar's mother Hamida Banu, a renowned collector, possessed and perhaps commissioned manuscripts such as the *Ramayana*. Similarly, Abdur Rahim Khan-i-Khana commissioned his own version of the *Ramayana*. These manuscripts exemplify the patronage that fuelled the dissemination of Mughal artistic traditions. The spread of the new Mughal style was further facilitated by the migration of artists, particularly to early Rajput courts such as Bundi, Bikaner, and Mewar.

Module 5: Limning arts of Deccani Kingdoms: Exuberance and wonder as aesthetic tropes.

The Deccan's strategic position as a crossroads of various cultures gave rise to an incredible effulgence of aesthetic forms marked by vivid illustrations of dreamlike wonder. Alongside Golconda and Ahmadnagar, the court at Bijapur, fostered historic connections to distant regions which contributed to the cosmopolitan nature of courts. This cultural amalgamation flourished under Ibrahim Adil Shah II and played a crucial role in shaping the artistic heritage of South Asia. We will critically examine the role of visual tropes in articulating syncretism, power and influence.

Module 6: Re-imagining the 15th century in the 17th century: Remaking history under Jahangir and Shah Jahan.

Jahangir and Shah Jahan actively connected their rule to their Central Asian Timurid ancestry. This "reengagement" served to legitimize their power by linking them to past conquerors, define a distinct Mughal identity separate from their predecessors, and harness a grander imperial legacy. Commissioned art and calligraphic texts, especially those compiled into magnificent albums or *muraqqas* as well as the *Padshahnama* prepared for Shah Jahan went hand in hand with revived/reformed courtly rituals that reflected this effort to weave the Timurid past into the fabric of the Mughal present. This took place against the backdrop of the entry of other major European powers into the Mughal court, which introduced newer European artistic styles. The module will look at cycles of adoption and rejection, and the influence of aesthetic choices on court politics.

Module 7: 'Sons of Kings': The creation of courtly identities and political affinities in the Rajput Courts

This module examines the political and aesthetic circuits of Rajput courts, their role in the circulation of courtly culture, painters, styles in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. It frames 'Rajputs' and 'Rajput Paintings' in critical discourse, addresses historiographic classifications such as 'indigenous' and 'foreign' and provides an overview of some of the major Rajput and Pahari schools of paintings. It discusses the role of the Deccan in the transmission of aesthetic and cultural ideas, at Rajput courts in Rajasthan, the Pahari hill states and the connectives that accrued. It also reflects on the rejection/ acceptance of "Mughalized" idioms at Rajput courts to notate political relationships with the Mughals.

Module 8: Kingship, Gender and Framing the Ideal: Patrons, artists, portraiture and representation. This module will take a comparative approach to models of kingship and masculinities seen in paintings and albums made for the courts of Akbar, Jahangir, Ibrahim Adil Shah, Mewar, and Pahari paintings from the courts at Mandi, Guler and Jasrota. It will look at artists as agents and mediators in the actualization of their patrons' fashioning/self-fashioning. The module will also locate women as subjects and patrons, their selfhood, sociability and desires on the one hand and the construction and representation of the feminine ideal, on the other.

Module 9: Sensoria: Connoisseurship, devotion and performativity

This module will explore the highly synaesthetic realms that were accommodated within courtly cultures and beyond, between the 16th and 18th centuries. It will dive into intermedial aesthetics of music, poetry and paintings through texts such as the Ragmalas from north, central Indian and the Deccan, the Kitab I Nauras from Bijapur, paintings at the court of Kishangarh, and the connectives with the Deccan in the writings of Savant Singh, as well as paintings made for the Vallabha Sampradaya at Kotah. It will discuss the performative relationship between eros, rasa and connoisseurship, pleasure and devotion within the diverse cultural contexts.

Module 10: Rounding up: The Arts of the book in India at the turn of 18th century and its legacies beyond

This last module will offer an overview of the patronage of Nawabs and Nabobs (Europeans collectors and connoisseurs), journey through Delhi, Awadh, Murshidabad and Benaras, and study some of the albums created in this period that left long legacies across continents. We will study the significance of patronizing the arts in politically and culturally fraught times, the movement of artists, circulation of paintings within groups of patrons and regions and address the complexities of 'copying' and citation.

Field Classes: (Dates To be confirmed)

Visit to the Painting Gallery of the National Museum

Visit to Nizamuddin/Humayun's tomb area to look at some of the newly restored decorative wall paintings.

Learning Outcomes:

Upon completing this course students will be able to:

- Gain a strong foundation in painting in South Asia between the 16th and 18th centuries, including its historical development and genres.
- Trace artistic and cultural networks across different regions, styles and periods.
- Develop the ability to critically examine the categories used to construct our understanding of the material past.
- Learn to "read" paintings by analysing how both content and form contribute to their meaning.

- Develop skills to effectively describe and critically analyse paintings in relation to various sources, including text, material culture, and visual art.

Grading Rubric:

Students will be assessed continually through the entire semester including active class and participation, mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading pattern is as follows:

Class participation and engagement : 10% of total grades. This includes engagement during field visits.

Class presentations : 30% of total grades. 15% will be for presentations and 15% for the written essays (No more than 2 pages, double spaced, 12 pt font) on the topic of the presentation. It should include citations and additional pages for selected images. The entire document should not exceed 4 pages. Essays should be submitted within one week of the class presentation. Details, dates and roster of presentations will be discussed in class.

Mid-term assessment: 10% of total grades. This will be an in-class cataloguing exercise. Students will be given a selection of images. They will be asked to write brief notes on any 4 of the images provided. (Date: 3rd October 2024).

Proposal for end semester essay: 15% of total grades. Students will have to provide a 200-300 word proposal for their end semester essay on a topic of their choosing, after consultation with the instructor. The proposal should include a working title, identify and address the central research question of the proposed paper, and provide a context for it. It should also include a preliminary bibliography. (This will be in addition to the 200-300 word limit for the main text of the proposal). Key words can be listed separately, but it's not mandatory.

End semester essay: 35% of total grades. Students will be expected to write a 2000-2500 words essay on their proposed topic. It should be well structured and include an introduction, a brief historiography, the body should be divided into paragraphs and a conclusion. Footnotes should follow proper citation styles and a final bibliography has to be provided at the end. (Bibliography should not be part of the word limit mentioned above).

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted.

Academic Integrity: Please be careful to cite and mark quotes from reference material. Any form of plagiarism or over reliance on AI tools to construct your essays will not be tolerated. Please write your own sentences without aid. Minor grammatical errors are okay.

Selected Readings:

Aitken, Molly Emma. *The Intelligence of Tradition in Rajput Court Painting*. Yale University Press, 2010.

- Asher, Catherine B., and Cynthia Talbot. *India Before Europe*. Cambridge University Press, 2006.
- Beach, M.C. *Early Mughal Painting*. Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1987.
- Beach, M.C. *Mughal and Rajput Painting (The New Cambridge History of India)*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1992.
- Beach, Milo, Ebberhard Fischer, and B.N. Goswamy. *Masters of Indian Painting*. Vols. 1 and 2, Delhi: Niyogi Books, 2015.
- Beach, Milo Cleveland, *The Imperial Image: Paintings for the Mughal Court*. Washington: Freer Gallery of Art, 1981.
- Beach, Milo Cleveland, "Jahangir's Jahangirnāma," *The Powers of Art*, ed. Barbara Stoler Miller, Delhi (Oxford University Press), 1992. 224-34.
- Beach, M.C. *The Grand Mogul - Imperial Painting in India, 1600-1660*, Williamstown, 1978.
- Behl, Aditya. *Love's Subtle Magic: An Indian Islamic Literary Tradition, 1379-1545*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2012.
- Beveridge, A.S., trans. *Gulbadan Begum's The History of Humāyūn (Humāyūn-Nāma)*. Delhi: Idarah-i Adabiyāt-i Delli, 1972. Introduction.
- Branfoot, Crispin. *Portraiture in South Asia Since the Mughals: Art, Representation and History*. Bloomsbury Publishing, 2018.
- Brand, Michael, and Glenn D. Lowry, eds. *Fatehpur Sikri: Art from the Mughal City of Victory*. Asia Society, New York, 1985.
- Brend, Barbara. *The Emperor Akbar's Khamsa of Nizāmī*. London: British Library; 1995.
- Canby, Sheila R. *Persian Painting*. London: British Museum Press, 1993.
- Canby, Sheila, ed. *Humayun's Garden Party: Princes of the House of Timur and Early Mughal Painting*. Mumbai: Marg Publications, 1994.
- Chakravarty, Anjan. *Indian Miniature Painting*. New Delhi: Roli, 2005.
- Chanchani, Nachiket. "Telling Tales: The Freer 'Vasanta Vilasa.'" *Artibus Asiae* 72, no. 1 (2012): 123–40.
- Chandra, Moti. "Portraits of Ibrahim Adil Shah II". *Marg*. Vol. 5 Issue no. 1. 22-28.
- Chandra, Pramod. *On the Study of Indian Art*. New York, 1983. Ch. 3.
- Chanchal Dadlani, "Transporting India: The Gentil Album and Mughal Manuscript Culture", *Art History* 38 (2015), pp. 748–61.
- Crill, Rosemary, Susan Stronge, Andrew Topsfield, London *Arts of Mughal India. Studies in Honour of Robert Skelton*, (Victoria and Albert Museum and Mapin Publishing), 2004.
- Das, Asok Kumar, ed. *Mughal Masters: Further Studies*. Mumbai: Marg Publications.

Das, AK. *Mughal Painters During Jahangir's Time*. Calcutta, 1978.

Del Bontà, Robert J. "Illustrating the Lives of the Jinas: Early Paintings from the Kalpasūtra." *Jaina Studies: Newsletter of the Centre of Jaina Studies* 2 (2007): 28-31.

Desai, Vishakha N. "Reflections of the past in the present: Copying processes in Indian painting." *Perceptions of South Asia's Visual Past* (1994): 135-148.

Desai, Vishakha N., B.N. Goswamy, and Ainslie Thomas Embree. *Life at Court: Art for India's Rulers, 16th-19th Centuries*. Boston, Mass: Museum of Fine Arts, 1985.

Desai, Vishakha N. "Painting and Politics in Seventeenth-Century North India: Mewār, Bikāner, and the Mughal Court." *Art Journal* 49.4 (1990): 370-378.

Desai, Vishakha N. "Timeless Symbols: Royal Portraits from Rajasthan, 17th-19th centuries," in Karine Schomer, ed., *The Idea of Rajasthan*. Delhi: Manohar, 1994. 313-342.

Diamond, Debra. "Holi in the Zenana: Genre, Style and Sociability," in *A Magic World: New Visions of Indian Painting*. Mumbai: Marg Publications, 2017, 100-115.

Dadlani, Chanchal. "Transporting India: The Gentil Album and Mughal Manuscript Culture." *Art History* 38 (2015): 748-61.

Digby, Simon. "The Literary Evidence for Painting in the Delhi Sultanate." *Bulletin of the American Academy of Benares (Varanasi)* 1 (1967): 47-58.

Findley, Ellison B. "Nur Jahan: A Woman's Power in a Mughal Court." *Manushi*, no. 84 (1994): 14-21.

Findley, Ellison B. "The Pleasure of Women: Nur Jahan and Mughal Painting." *Asian Art* 6, no. 2 (1993): 66-86.

Flood, Finbarr Barry. "Before the Mughals: Material Culture of Sultanate North India." *Muqarnas Online* 36.1 (2019): 1-39.

Flatt, Emma. "The Authorship and Significance of the Nujūm al-'ulūm: A Sixteenth-Century Astrological Encyclopedia from Bijapur." *Journal of the American Oriental Society* 131.2 (2011): 223-244.

Garimella, Annapurna. ed., *The Long Arc of South Asian Art: Essays in Honour of Vidya Dehejia*. New Delhi: Women Unlimited in association with Mumbai: The Marg Foundation, 2022.

Golombek, Lisa, and Maria Subtelny, eds. *Timurid Art and Culture*. Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill, 1992.

Goswamy, B.N. *A Jainesque Sultanate Shahnama and the context of pre-Mughal painting in India*. Museum Rietberg, 1988.

Goswamy, B.N. "Pahari Painting: The Family as the Basis of Style". *Marg*. Vol. 21 Issue no. 4; September 1968. 17-62.

Goswamy, B.N, and Eberhard Fischer. *Pahari Masters: Court Painters of Northern India*. Oxford University Press, USA, 1997.

Haidar, Navina Najat, and Marika Sardar, eds. *Sultans of the South: Arts of India's Deccan Courts, 1323-1687*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2011.

Hutton, Deborah. *Art of the Court of Bijapur* (Indiana, 2006).

Jasanoff, Maya. *Edge of Empire: Conquest and Collecting in the East, 1750–1850*. London, 2006.

Khera, Dipti. “Jagvilasa: Picturing Worlds of Pleasure and Power in 18th-Century Udaipur Painting,” in Molly Aitken, ed. *A Magic World: New Visions of Indian Painting*. Mumbai: Marg Publications, 2017. 74-87.

Khan, Murad Mumtaz. *Faces of God: Images of Devotion in Indo-Muslim Painting, 1500–1800*. Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill, 2023.

Koch, Ebba. *The Planetary King: Humayun Padshah, Inventor and Visionary on the Mughal Throne*. Ahmedabad: Mapin Publishing, 2022.

Koch, Ebba. “The influence of the Jesuit Missions on Symbolic Representations of the Mughal Empire,” in *Mughal Art and Imperial Ideology. Collected Essays*, Ebba Koch, Oxford and New Delhi, 2001. 1-11.

Koch, Ebba. “The Mughal Emperor as Solomon, Majnun, and Orpheus, or The Album as a Think Tank for Allegory.” *Muqarnas*, vol. 27, 2010. 277–311.

Koch, Ebba. “*Jahangir and the Angels: Recently Discovered Wall Paintings Under European Influence in the Fort of Lahore*” in *Mughal Art and Imperial Ideology. Collected Essays*, Oxford and New Delhi, 2001. 1-11.

Koch, Ebba. “The Hierarchical Principles of Shah Jahani Painting”, in Milo Beach et al (eds) *The King of the World: An Imperial Manuscript from the Royal Library, Windsor Castle*. London: Thames and Hudson, 1997. 130-143.

Leach, Linda York. *Paintings from India, the Nasser D. Khalili Collection of Islamic Art*, volume VIII, The Nour Foundation, London, 1998 (the 'Hamida Banu' pages).

Losty, J.P. *The Art of the Book in India*. London: The British Library, 1982.

Michell, George, and Mark Zebrowski. *Architecture and Art of the Deccan Sultanates*. New York: Cambridge University Press, 1999.

Moura Carvalho, Pedro. *Mir'āt Al-quds (Mirror of Holiness): A Life of Christ for Emperor Akbar: A Commentary on Father Jerome Xavier's Text and the Miniatures of Cleveland Museum of Art, Acc. No. 2005.145*. Netherlands: Brill, 2011. 1-8.

Natif, Mika. *Mughal Occidentalism*. Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill, 2018.

Orsini, Francesca ed. *Love in South Asia: A Cultural History*, edited by Francesca Orsini. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.

Orsini, Francesca, and Samira Sheikh, eds. *After Timur Left: Culture and Circulation in Fifteenth Century North India*. Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2014.

Parodi, Laura ed. *The Visual World of Muslim India: The Art, Culture and Society of the Deccan in the Early Modern Era*. London: Tauris Academic Studies, 2014. 205-232.

Rice, Yael. *The Brush of Insight: Artists and Agency at the Mughal Court*. Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2023.

Rice, Yael, and Dipti Khera, eds. *Readings on Painting: From 75 Years of Marg*. Vol. 74, No. 4, and Vol. 75, No. 1. Mumbai: Marg, 2023.

Sen, Geeti. *Paintings from the Akbarnama: A Visual Chronicle of Mughal India*. Calcutta: Lustre Press under arrangement with Rupa, 1984.

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Seyller, John. "Overpainting in the Cleveland Tutinama," *Artibus Asiae* 52, nos ¾, 1992. 283-318.

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Sharma, Mahesh and Padma Kaimal ed. *Indian Painting: Themes, History and Interpretations (Essays in Honour of B.N. Goswamy)* Ahmedabad: Mapin Publishing, 2013.

Singh, Kavita. *Real Birds in Imagined Gardens: Mughal Painting between Persia and Europe*. Getty Research Institute Council Lecture. Los Angeles, CA: Getty Research Institute, 2017.

Singh, Kavita. "A Knowing Look: Appropriation and Subversion of the Mughal Idiom in Rajput Paintings of the Eighteenth Century." *Synergies in Visual Culture/Bildkulturen im Dialog*. Wilhelm Fink, 2013. 257-268.

Singh, Kavita, and Parul Singh. *Book of Gold: The Kanchana Chitra Ramayana of Banaras*. India: Museum of Art & Photography, 2023.

Skelton, Robert, "The Ni'mat nama: A Landmark in Malwa Painting." *Marg* 12/3 (1959): 44-48.

Skelton, Robert, et al. eds. *Facets of Indian Art*. London: V&A, 1982.

Soucek, Priscilla P. "Persian Artists in Mughal India: Influences and Transformations," *Muqarnas* 4 (1987).

Stronge, Susan. *Painting for the Mughal Emperor*. London: V&A Publications, 2002.

Thackston, Wheeler M., trans. and ed., *The Jahangirnama. Memoirs of Jahangir, Emperor of India*, Freer Gallery of Art and Arthur M. Sackler Gallery, Washington D.C., New York and Oxford (Oxford University Press), 1999.

Thackston, W.M., trans. *The Baburnama : Memoirs of Babur Prince and Emperor*. Modern Library pbk. ed. New York: Modern Library; 2002. (Selected excerpts).

Truschke, Audrey, *Culture of Encounters: Sanskrit at the Mughal Court*. New York, NY: Columbia University Press, 2016. 64-100.

Truschke, Audrey, John Seyller, Marika Sardar, eds. *The Ramayana of Hamida Banu Begum: Queen Mother of Mughal India*. Italy: Museum of Islamic Art, 2021.

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Zebrowski, Mark. *Deccani Painting*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983.

Figure Drawing as Remembering and Reimagining

Course Code: VA-2016

Course Instructor: Anni Kumari

Course Level: 2000

Prerequisites: None

Course Description:

In Western academic art education, figurative drawing was until recently considered the foundation, the essential prerequisite for mastering disciplines of painting, sculpture, frescos, and murals. Although it is no longer a requisite skill for contemporary artists, a high proportion would still agree that irrespective of whatever material they might choose to work in, they 'think' in terms of drawings. Drawing is more than simply a skill in that it offers a path to self-discovery, revealing a cast of minds, an imaginative capacity, and a mode of perception.

This course encourages students to re-think and re-imagine the human body beyond a representational image, as an entity with constant trans-mutative possibilities regarding form, functionality, and aesthetics. Through a combination of practice and discourse, the course encourages explorations beyond human anatomy by focusing on the varied manifestations and meanings ascribed to the human figure, vis-à-vis the body, in the context of visual art and beyond. Students will be introduced to contemporary artistic practices and deliberations on artistic visions, experiences, and wisdom that push the boundaries of accepted notions of 'high' art and critique hierarchies of attitude. Tracing the history of figure drawing as a genre that goes back to Classical antiquity to the Italian Renaissance, extending into the 18th-century French academia and the 19th-

century Victorian Era, students will get a broad overview of how the established notion of accuracy and idealized beauty continues to be challenged and reinvented as artists take on a variety of approaches to drawing the human figure.

The course looks at how the idealized notion of body is challenged and replaced with bodies that are bruised, grotesque, and out of proportion with visible stretch marks, skin hair, wrinkles, and pigmentation. How has the conscious shift towards drawing from memory and imagination as opposed to drawing from a live model or from photographic references allowed artists to create works that are often loaded with political commentary and emotive power?

In this course, students have the flexibility to work with both analogue and digital mediums and materials enabling them to connect to their context, concerns, and interests with a sense of immediacy by using the human figure as a trigger.

The frameworks we will be working through the course include:

- Understanding the various kinds of representations of the human figure - from different social and cultural contexts. Locating discursive modes of representation.
- Probing ideas of beauty, identity, sexuality, and gender, through human form.
- Understanding space-time and memory in the context of the human body and its representation.
- Exploring the human figure in contemporary drawings under the broad categorizations of the body, self, personal lives, social reality, and fiction.
- Reflecting on processes of overlapping, erasures, and incision as acts layered with emotive and intuitive sensibilities.
- Developing an individual methodology /strategy for figurative drawing.

The course will unfold over three modules; each spread over four weeks respectively and will include both theoretical readings and practical assignments.

Module 1:

The human figure in visual arts:

A historical perspective, a cultural and social perspective.

Representing the human body- a repository of concepts.

Overview- Western naturalism through the Renaissance, Human form in Egyptian Drawing,

Indian painting, and Human form.

Basic observational drawings.

Portraiture and history painting.

The Renaissance body- Leonardo, Michelangelo Raphael, Durer

Representing flesh and desire- Boucher, Ingre, Rubens,

Modernity and Body - Humor, satire, and politics of expressing the Body in painting, and sculpture. (Manet, van Gogh, Rodin, Daumier,

Drawing from archival works,

Conceptualizing a space for the body – Giorgio de Chirico, Piranesi, Escher,

Module 2:

Body as a biological entity

Anatomy studies, life drawing, studies in biology, and medical discourse.

Triumph of realism in representations of the body
 Drawing the body- precision in Biology
 Structures of form- synthesizing biological and organic material.

Module 3:

The human figure in Contemporary Art
 Body as a Phenomenological Tool
 Expressionism, Surrealism, Body and Conceptual Art, Feminism, Neo-expressionism, the Popular
 Depictions through drawing and photography, - Ana Mendieta, Janine Antoni,
 Body as a performative tool. - Marina Abramovic, Yoko Ono, Rumana Hussain
 Depictions through journaling, everyday bodies – Louise Bourgeois, Chittoprasad, Arpita Singh,
 Body as wear and tear, absences, fragmented, diseased – Kiki Smith, Eva Hesse, Anthony Gormley
 Body as text and body as material- Jenny Holzer, Nalini Malani, Mithu Sen, Juul Krajer
 Body as Monuments of Social Expression. – Doh Ho Suh, Kara Walker, William Kentridge

Learning Outcomes:

The course is expected to make students aware of the significant position of the human figure in art, especially in the context of drawing and conceptualization.
 Some of the key concepts on culture and representation will be explored- realism, mimesis, illustration, and the role of fantasy and memory in the process of artistic production.
 Students will learn about fundamental techniques of representation through observation and imaging.
 Students will learn processes, mediums, and materials employed by artists, both historically and in contemporary times.

Select Readings & Requirements (Reading List and other materials):

Gombrich, E. H. The Story of Art. Phaidon, 1995.
 Seligman, Isabel, et al. Lines of THOUGHT: Drawing from Michelangelo to Now. Thames & Hudson, 2016.
 Laurenza, Domenico. Art and Anatomy in Renaissance Italy: Images from a Scientific Revolution. Metropolitan Museum of Art, 2012.
 McLean, Cheryl, and Brown, Clint. Drawing from Life. United Kingdom, Wadsworth/Thomson, 2004.
 Keele, Kenneth D., and Jane Roberts. Leonardo Da Vinci: Anatomical Drawings from the Royal Collection, Windsor Castle. Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1983.
 Hale, Robert Beverly. Drawing Lessons from the Great Masters. Watson-Guptill Publications, 1964.
 Benjamin A. Rifkin, Michael J. Ackerman. (2006) Human Anatomy (From the Renaissance to the Digital Age)
 Richard Barnett(2014). The Sick Rose: Disease and the Art of Medical Illustration
 Malbert, Roger, and Sarah Prall. Drawing People: The Human Figure in Contemporary Art. Thames and Hudson, 2016.

Bell, Julian, et al. Ways of Drawing: Artists' Perspectives and Practices. Thames and Hudson, 2019.

Additional readings:

Gardner, Helen, and Fred S. Kleiner. Gardner's Art through the Ages: The Western Perspective. Cengage Learning, 2021.

Man as Hero: The Human Figure in Western Art. W.W. Norton, 2005.

Thomson, Arthur. The Handbook of Anatomy for Art Students. Clarendon Pr., 1896.

Farnell, B. M. (2011). Theorizing “the Body” in Visual Culture. In M. Banks, & J. Ruby (Eds.), Made to Be Seen: Perspectives on the History of Visual Anthropology (pp. 136-158). University of Chicago Press

Rice, Pierce.

Grading Rubric:

Continuous assessment throughout the semester on the basis of class assignments, readings and contribution to class discussions.

Grading Rubrics for assignments:

Dedicated work in images. (stipulated number of drawings will not be enough to produce quality in work. Quality of drawing will be dependent on learning skills. Each assignment will have grading based on your skills of boldness, willingness to experiment, dedication at work and bringing minute observations onto your media form. The essay will look at your understanding of concepts and relation with the world of visuals.)

Mid-Term assessment:

Assignment 1 (20%),

Attendance (20%),

End semester assessment:

Assignment 2 (25%),

Assignment 3 (25 %),

Display (10 %)

Attendance Policy

2 absences need no prior approval or medical documentation.

(Each class is for 3 hours, taking two weekly sessions together)

Visual and Material Cultures of the Himalayas

Course Code: VA 2006/ SOA 2215/ MS 3098

Course Instructor: Latika Gupta

Level of the Course: 1000/2000/3000

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: Mon, Wed. 4.40 pm-6.10 pm

Course Description:

This course focuses on the Western Himalayas to understand how visual and material cultures are intrinsically connected with the idea of ‘place’. We will look at how places, cultures and people are constructed through representations — visual and written — both by ‘outsiders’ as well as local communities. Utilising interdisciplinary methodologies borrowing from visual anthropology, material culture studies, museology and history, students will engage with critical questions about the ethics of representation in imaging ‘other’ places and people, the socio-political processes that inform the making of tradition, and the entanglements of politics and culture in the formation of regional and national identities.

We will read a contemporary novel, early travel accounts, do a deep dive into colonial and contemporary photography, watch films and look at representations in popular culture. Through field visits to a Tibetan exile settlement and a museum in Delhi, we will study material culture in relationship to its uses and the recontextualization of sacred objects within museum spaces.

Some of the questions we will explore include: How are cultures constructed through acts of museumisation? How did the field of ‘Himalayan Art’ emerge? Where do we ‘locate’ this field; which geographical areas and religions are made emblematic of this discipline; which cultures are excluded and why? How were museum collections built and in what historical circumstances? What curatorial strategies are used to reconstruct the auras of objects? How are sacred objects of use segregated into categories of art and ethnography?

We will also examine the recent museum-making impulse in the Himalayas through case studies of a range of museums situated in these borderlands — war memorial museums, community museums of conflict and trade route artefacts, and museums in Buddhist monasteries to understand the relationship between heritage and religion, the impact of the movement of things from sacred sites to ‘secular’ museums, and to ask how a politics of remembrance may manifest in cultural production. The course will conclude with an introduction to Tibetan/ Buddhist culture-in-exile through contemporary Tibetan art, poetry, writing and films.

The course will consist of illustrated lectures and seminars in which active participation will be expected of students. Readings for each seminar class will be assigned beforehand.

Learning Outcomes:

By the end of the course, students:

- will be familiar with the broad field of the visual and material cultures in the Western Himalayas in Tibet, Ladakh and Himachal Pradesh.
- will learn about major museums and collections of Himalayan Art and be able to critically analyze the framing of objects as art or ethnography, and questions of provenance research and label writing in object displays.

- will be conversant with critical questions around heritage, the politics of museums and the role of tradition in the construction of contemporary cultural identities.
- will acquire the critical tools to interrogate the nature and impact of ‘representation’ of regions, cultures and communities through images and written texts.
- will be able to analyse and read images and texts, with a focus on meaning making through vocabularies and terminologies, and apply this critical thinking in a curatorial project.

Grading Rubric:

Students will be graded on the basis of active participation in class seminars, on written assignments, a curated exhibition and presentation. Assignments will be evaluated for originality of thinking, critical analysis and clearly expressed arguments. Plagiarism will not be tolerated.

- Seminar Participation: 20%
- Mid semester report (1000 words): 25%
- Curated exhibition and Presentation: 25%
- End Semester essay (2000-2500 words including footnotes, bibliography): 30%

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted. However, since grading will be based on continuous assessment through the semester, absences during participative seminars will result in a reduction in the overall grade.

Select Reading List:

- Anand, Dibyesh. “Western Colonial Representations of the Other- The Case of Exotica Tibet”, *New Political Science* 29 (1) March 2007, 23-42.
- Appadurai, Arjun. “The Production of locality” *Modernity at Large: Cultural Dimensions of Globalization*, University of Minnesota Press, 1996, 178-200.
- Appadurai, Arjun. “Putting Hierarchy in its Place” *Cultural Anthropology* Vol. 3, No. 1, Place and Voice in Anthropological Theory (Feb., 1988), pp. 36-49.
- Banerjee, Sandeep. “Not Altogether Unpicturesque: Samuel Bourne and the Landscaping of the Victorian Himalaya”, *Victorian Literature and Culture*, Vol. 42, No. 3 (2014), Cambridge University Press, 351-368.
- Bishop, Peter (2000) *The Sacred Myth of Shangri-La: Tibet, Travel Writing and the Western Creation of Sacred Landscape*. New Delhi: Adarsh Enterprises, 2000.
- Buggeln, Gretchen, C. Paine, S. Brent Plate (Eds.) *Religion in Museums: Global and Multidisciplinary Perspectives*, Bloomsbury Academic, 2017.
- Carrington, Michael. “Officers, Gentlemen and Thieves: The Looting of Monasteries during the 1903/4 Younghusband Mission to Tibet” *Modern Asian Studies*, Volume 37, Issue 01, February 2003, pp.81-109
- Chanchani, Nachiket. “Folding and Faulting: The Formation of ‘Himalayan Art’”, *South Asian*

Studies, 34:2, 2018, 93-113.

- Chaudhary, Zahid R. Chapter 3: “Armor and Aesthesis- The Picturesque in Difference”, *Afterimage of Empire: Photography in Nineteenth Century India*, University of Minnesota Press, 2012.
- Fewkes, Jacqueline H. “Perspectives on Shangri-La: Understanding Place, Regional Identity and Tourism Discourses in Ladakh” in *The Draw of the Hills*, (Ed.) Latika Gupta, Marg Vol. 69 No.4, 2018.
- Friese, Kai. “The Aryan Handshake” *Transition*, No.83 (2000), 4-35.
- Gayly, Holly. “Introduction | Theorizing the Secular in Tibetan Cultural Worlds” *Himalaya*, Volume 36, No.1, May 2016.
- Grimes, Ronald (1992) ‘Sacred Objects in Museums Spaces’ in *Studies in Religion/Sciences Religieuses* 21 (4), pp 419-30
- Gupta, Radhika "The Importance of Being Ladakhi: Affect and Artifice in Kargil". *HIMALAYA* 32(1), 2013
- Gupta, Radhika "Islam in the Trans-Himalayan ecumene" in Jelle J.P. Wouters, Michael T. Heneise (Eds) *Routledge Handbook of Highland Asia*, 2022
- Harris, Clare. *In the Image of Tibet: Tibetan Painting after 1959*. London: Reaktion Books, 1999.
- Harris, Clare. *Photography and Tibet*. London: Reaktion Books, 2016.
- Harris, Clare. *The Museum on the Roof of the World: Art, Politics and the Representation of Tibet*, University of Chicago Press, 2014.
- Harris, Clare. “The Potala Palace: Remembering to Forget in Contemporary Tibet” *South Asian Studies*, 29:1, 2013, pp. 61-75,
- Harrison, Victoria S. 2021. Introduction to the Special Issue “Religion in Museums”. *Religions* 12: 139. <https://doi.org/10.3390/rel12020139>
- Heimsath, Kabir M. “Untitled Identities: Contemporary Art in Lhasa, Tibet” *Asianart.com*, 2005.
- Heimsath, Kabir M. “Lhasa Nights”
<https://www.asianart.com/exhibitions/lhasanights/index.html>
- Hopkirk, Peter. *Trespassers on the Roof of the World- The Race for Lhasa*. Oxford University Press, 1983.
- Huber, Toni. (Ed.) *Sacred Spaces and Powerful Places in Tibetan Culture-A Collection of Essays*. Dharamsala: LTWA, 1999.
- Klassen, Pamela E. “Narrating Religion Through Museums” *MacMillan Interdisciplinary Handbook*, pp. 333-352.
- Linrothe, Rob. “Photography, painting, and prints in Ladakh and Zangskar. Intermediality and transmediality” *Études mongoles et sibériennes, centrasiatiques et tibétaines*, 51, 2020.
- Lopez Jr. Donald S. *Prisoners of Shangri-La: Tibetan Buddhism and the West*. Chicago and London: University of Chicago Press, 1999.
- Macdonald, Sharon. “Collecting Practices”, in Macdonald, Sharon (ed) *A Companion to*

Museum Studies, Oxford: Blackwell, 2011, pp. 81-97.

- Mathur, S. and Singh K. (Eds.) No Spitting, No Touching, No Praying: The Museum in South Asia, Routledge, 2015.
- Martin, Emma. “Collecting Tibet: Dreams and Realities”, Journal of Museum Ethnography, No. 30 (March 2017), pp. 59-78.
- Martin, Emma. “Charles Bell’s collection of ‘curios’: Acquisitions and encounters during a Himalayan Journey” in S. Dudley, AJ Barnes, J Binnie, J Petrov & J. Walklate (eds), Narrating Objects, Collecting Stories: Essays in Honour of Professor Susan M. Pearce. Routledge, London, pp. 167-183.
- McMillin, Laurie Hovell. English in Tibet, Tibet in English: Self Presentation in Tibet and the Diaspora, NY: Palgrave, 2001
- Mitchell, W.J.T. (Ed.) Landscape and Power, University of Chicago Press, 1994. 5
- Myatt, Tim. “Trinkets, Temples, and Treasures: Tibetan Material Culture and the 1904 British Mission to Tibet” http://himalaya.socanth.cam.ac.uk/collections/journals/ret/pdf/ret_21_07.pdf
- Paine, Crispin. Godly Things: Museums, Objects and Religion. Leicester: Leicester University Press, 2000.
- Paine, Crispin. Religious Objects in Museums: Private Lives and Public Duties. London, Bloomsbury, 2013.
- Pearce, Susan M. (Ed.) Interpreting Objects and Collections, London and NY: Routledge, 2003.
- Singh, Kavita. “Repatriating without Patria- Repatriating for Tibet” Journal of Material Culture, Vol. 15 (2), 2010, 131-155.
- Sonam, Tenzing. “A Stranger in my Native Land” TibetWrites, 2000.
- Sutherland, Patrick. “Photographing Spiti” in The Draw of the Hills, (Ed.) Latika Gupta, Marg Vol. 69 No.4, 2018.
- Lama, Tsering Yangzom, We Measure The Earth With Our Bodies, Published by Bloomsbury India, 2022
- Tsundue, Tenzin, Kora- Stories and Poems, 2002
- Tythacott, Luoise and Chiara Bellini, “Deity and Display: Meanings, Transformations and Exhibitions of Tibetan Buddhist Objects”, Religions 2020, 11, 106.
- Willis, Michael (2015) ‘Detritus to Treasure: Memory, Metonymy, and the Museum’ in Sullivan, Bruce (ed) (2015) Sacred Objects in Secular Spaces: Exhibiting Asian Religions in Museums, London: Bloomsbury, pp 145-152.
- Wingfield, Christopher (2010) ‘Touching the Buddha: encounters with a charismatic object’ in Sandra Dudley (ed.) Museum Materialities: Objects, Engagements, Interpretations. London and New York: Routledge, pp 53-70.

Course Name: Visual Storytelling

Course Code: VA-2010/ MS-1081

Course Instructor: Vishwajyoti Ghosh [vishwajyoti.ghosh@ashoka.edu.in]

Semester/ Term: Monsoon 2024

Course Prerequisite: None

Attendance Policy: 90% minimum attendance

Prerequisites: Narrative based research, writing, basic drawing/ doodling, basic research photography, basic mobile photography.

VISUAL STORYTELLING: Through Graphic and Sequential Narratives

Course Description:

This course seeks to engage with this fast-moving genre of visual storytelling through comics and graphic narratives with research led and inter-disciplinary approach, in sync with the student's core area of interest or discipline.

In sync with the time's media or information dissemination, it is important to learn and practice visual storytelling as both a language and a medium that can be incorporated in one's individual academic discipline. This approach can help the students in articulating their learnings, research and storytelling in multi-disciplinary formats that is much required in today's realm of information & content, where visual storytelling is an alternate and a popular form of information, opinion and communication.

As the world's reading engagement is rapidly shrinking into a palm sized mobile, the engagement with the visual is rapidly becoming the new language, with the binaries between the texts and visuals fading away. In these times visual storytelling is making a strong space for itself in every form of information or content. Be it journalism, health information, economics or plain fiction, the visual approach is now here to stay, in an age where the best of storytelling, poetry, journalism or reportage are now visually led.

Visual Storytelling is an ever-evolving medium. From the cave drawings documenting the hunter's life or the Egyptian clay tablets that documented the Pharaoh's philosophy or the Persian miniatures that visually documented the Ruler's court or the wars, the Pahadi miniatures that visually articulated the leelas of Radha Krishna to the visual documentation in the modern era, from the peasant sketches of Van Gogh, the daily life depicted by Seurat, Degas and more or the nightlife by Lautrec, the Mexican muralists like Deigo Rivera, Orzoco, Chittoprasad, Indian artists like Ram Kinkar Baij, Somenath Hore to the best graphic narratives of our times by Chris Ware, Satrapi, Joe Sacco and now to the world of You Tube and Tik Tok animations the form has only grown both in terms of practice but also viewership and acceptance. In the visual world we live now, it is a form with a moving language now blending with technology. This course will blend these influences into ones' own practice to create comics and graphic narratives in sync with the practitioner's area of interest and discipline.

This is not to say that all human centric works of art can be categorized as narrative artworks but graphic narratives have grown and imbibed many of these experiences in the making of graphic stories including films and popular culture. For a medium as absorbent as graphic storytelling, the form has drawn inspiration and acknowledged the same from multiple disciplines like painting, prose and poetry, filmmaking and even gaming. It's this multi-disciplinary influence and framework this course seeks to work with.

Graphic narratives can never be limited to a category but more than a form it has evolved to a medium that has embraced every subject which makes it a complete storytelling tool than an only entertainment or an informational one.

Learning Objectives:

The semester will be a sequential flow from the history of visual documentation and articulation to the modern practices of graphic novels, mobile cartoons, comic strips and now visual narratives on the mobile to a practice- based approach.

In the fast-moving visual world, students will learn to negotiate between the visuals and the written word in the process of crafting their individual narratives. The students will also explore and practice the modes and methods of visual storytelling through their chosen styles and influences. The expected outcome for the students will be practice based learning to develop their visual storytelling language, exploring the fluid connections between fact and fiction.

Select Readings & Requirements (Reading List and other materials):

Reading List:

Understanding Comics / Scott McCloud/ William Morrow Paperbacks; Reprint edition (27 April 1994)/ ISBN-10: 006097625X

Graphic Novels: The definitive guide / Paul Gravett/ Harper Design: ISBN: 0060824255

Journalism / Joe Sacco/ Jonathan Cape (14 June 2018)/ ISBN-10: 178733130X

Building Stories / Chris Ware/ / Jonathan Cape (4 October 2012)/ ISBN-10: 9780224078122

Documenting Trauma in Comics / Dominic Davies/ Palgrave Macmillan; 1st ed. 2020 edition (21 May 2020)/ ISBN 3030379973

Postcolonial Comics: Texts, Events, Identities/ Ed. by Binita Mehta, Pia Mukherji/ Routledge; 1st edition (4 May 2015)/ ISBN-10: 041573813X

The Indian Graphic Novel: Nation, history and critique/ Pramod K. Nayar/ Routledge; 1st edition (17 February 2016)/ ISBN-10 : 9781138962446

Viewing List:

Persepolis / Marjane Satrapi, Vincent / Paul Cox

Interviews with Joe Sacco, Chris Ware, Sudhir Patwardhan

Works by: Degas/ Chittoprasad/ Lautrec/ Van Gogh/ Somenath Hore / José Clemente Orozco/

Ram Kinkar Baij / Sudhir Patwardhan / Anupam Sud / Arpita Singh

Learning Outcomes:

The preliminary module of this course of 2 weeks will be a curated overview of the published, popular and the prevalent and emerging forms of visual storytelling in the world of graphic narratives and visuals. The idea would be exploring the diversity of practice across the globe and the processes involved in the making. The core idea here will be to discuss the forms and works to bring new practice-based influences and ideas, their working process and explore the architecture of visual storytelling in these works.

Weeks 1-2: Discuss works of art, graphic novels, cartoons, comic strips and create short narratives.

This will be a presentation and discussion-based approach discussing the presented works in detail and the stories behind making many of these works. The idea will be to discuss the journey of the works from the intent to execution and the struggles and transformations that make the narrative in the final output. For example, Van Gogh's study of the peasantry, the sketch book notes leading to the potato eaters or Somenath Hore's diaries documenting the Tebhaga movement or Marjane Satrapi's background story behind the making of Persepolis or Chris Ware's documentation of the American Midwest are some of the well-articulated stories in the making of these works.

Weeks 3-5: Ideate, research, explore graphic storytelling ideas and create micro books, zines etc.

This will be followed by 3 weeks to ideate, research, explore ideas of student's interest in their areas of discipline followed by field work, data collection and research on the ground. This will include visual data collection, interviews, recording, documentation and conceptualizing the idea based on the research.

This will lead to create micro books, zines etc.

Documentation of the research will be followed to process and distill the findings to create the core conceptual idea and be presented in the studio sessions for the benefit of collective brainstorming and discussions. These discussions with fellow classmates will lead to an inter-disciplinary ideation and conceptualization, moving closer to shape and sharpen the core project ideas of the students. The students will also be expected to share the processing of their research findings along with their influences and inspirations.

Weeks 6-7: Exploring possibilities of form, conceptualization, layout, architecture etc. and presentation of a final project idea followed by discussion on similar ideas & influences

Moving on from research the course will discuss the working process of creating a visual narrative using multiple influences of form and genres. This will include detailed discussions on the various possibilities of the form i.e. different forms that can be explored -doodle narratives, popular comics, mobile based narratives, photo comics, design, layouts, page architecture, typography, sequential storytelling and the work process involved in each, enabling the students to make informed choices in sync with their ideas.

Week 8: Presentation of a final project idea followed by discussion on similar ideas & influences

The following week the students will be expected to present their ideas and preliminary drafts as scribbles/ sketches with fellow batchmates, followed by open discussions, suggestions and ideation to evolve a clear understanding to flesh out the final narrative.

Each student/ project will be further exposed to similar works through display and in-depth discussions on influences and ideas related to the project to lend a visual and storytelling perspective, enabling the practitioner to take one's work further.

Besides creating multiple micro narratives through the semester, finally, the semester will move to its last weeks to create a bigger multi-page graphic narrative.

Weeks 9-14: Final completion with a mid-level presentation in week 11.

A mid-level draft presentation will be shared in the studio to display the work in progress after 2 weeks then followed by the final 4 weeks or the end of the semester, ready for display, presentation and production. Studio presence in these weeks will be a must.

Output Participation:

Though the output will be individual, the process of production will be based on field research, short studio collaborations and conversations and work-in-progress presentations at regular intervals as discussed above.

Course Deliverables: Every student will be expected to develop, produce multiple research-based short visual stories and graphic narratives/ comics.

Grading Rubric:

The ability to come up with original ideas, the skill to articulate visually.

Exploration, Execution– 40%

Ability to deeply enquire a wide variety of explorations and bring it into practice. To improvise and pivot when required. The journey from visualisation to final execution.

Problem Solving & Improvisation -10%

Having a methodological approach to address visual challenges. The willingness to connect ones academic practice and those notions to one's own work.

Teamwork, Class Participation, Time Management -10%

Efficiency and the capacity to manage time and participates in joint feedback sessions, collective display and collective work effectively

Technology in Art: From New Media to the NFTs (Non-fungible Tokens)

Course Code: VA- 2011 , MS 2397, Level 2000

Course Instructor: Srinivas Aditya Mopidevi

Course Level: 2000/3000 Undergraduate / Graduate

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: Friday. 3:10 -6:20pm.

Course Description:

This course focuses on the relationship between technology and art from the New Media Art of the 1990s to the present global circulation of digital artworks registered as non-fungible tokens (NFTs). New Media Art that emerged in the wake of digital technology expanded the scope of artistic practice whilst being critical to the technologies it was mobilizing. Art in the time of the NFTs turned artworks into digital assets transacted predominantly through crypto and registered on a decentralized global network ledger called the blockchain. Mapping art's integral relationship with technology this course will unpack the diverse trajectories of video, new media, and digital art forms that disrupted the clean categories of traditional art history. Further, it will investigate the economic dimensions that accompany the proliferation of digital assets discussing whether the emergence of the NFTs as a registering standard positioned art as an alibi to normalize crypto as a global tender.

The course begins by discussing the history of video art, from the early experiments of Nam June Paik to the immersive installations of Bill Viola, including seminal instances such as the Vision Exchange Workshop that led pioneering Indian artists Akbar Padamsee and Nalini Malani to explore the potentiality of video and animation. Drawing from the work of Ravi Sundaram, it will also discuss the proliferation of video and mobile phone technology across the Global South and how it transformed cultural production and consumption.

The course will also map the artistic responses to the internet & digital surveillance technology through the practices of Antoni Muntadas, Jodi Brothers, Rafael Lozano-Hemmer, Trevor Paglen, CAMP (Mumbai), Hito Steyerl, Shilpa Gupta, Raqs Media Collective, and others. Further, it will introduce students to contemporary art practices driven by artificial intelligence including Refik Anadol, Entangled Others Studio, and Pindar Var Arman.

Followed by a detailed analysis of the seminal practices in the history of technology and art, the course also critically engages with the economic and ecological implications of NFTs on contemporary art.

Learning Objectives:**By the end of this course, students:**

Will be well versed in the diverse histories of technology and art.

Will develop an understanding of art forms such as Video art, New Media art, AI art, and contemporary digital art in the NFT space.

Will develop a critical understanding of NFTs and their political and ecological impact.

Will learn the process of ideating, planning, and executing an art exhibition.

Course Deliverables:

The course will consist of illustrated lectures and seminars in which active participation will be expected of students.

Students will deliver:

One 500 word case study.

One presentation on five digital artworks of their choice.

A final exhibition project co-curated by the students of the course advised by the course instructor.

(*The material for the exhibition can be sourced from any artist, institution across the world contingent on the resources available at the department and university.)

Grading Rubrics:

Students will be graded on the basis of active participation in class seminars, their choice of topics, written components as well as the realization of the final project.

Class/ Seminar Participation: 20%

One 500 word case study - 15 %

One presentation on five digital artworks of their choice. 15%

Final project (1000 word group manifesto and a final project presentation): 50 %

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted. However, since grading will be based on continuous assessment through the semester, absences during participative seminars and presentations will result in a reduction in the overall grade.

Selected Bibliography

Christiane, Paul. *World of Art: Digital Art*. 2nd edition. London: Thames & Hudson, 2008.

Cook, Sara and Beryl Graham. *Rethinking Curating: Art After New Media*. London: The MIT Press, 2010.

Gitelman, Lisa and Geoffrey B. Pingree, edited. *New Media 1740 – 1915*, 11–22. Massachusetts: The MIT Press, 2004.

Manovich, Lev. *The Language of the New Media*. Cambridge: The MIT Press, 2001.

Marc Beckman, *The Comprehensive Guide to NFTs, Digital Artwork, and Blockchain Technology*, Skyhorse, 2021

Vall, Renee van. *At the Edges of Vision: A phenomenological Aesthetics of Contemporary Spectatorship*. Hampshire: Ash Gate, 2008.

Snow Philippa, 'Are NFTs really art?', *The Guardian*,
<https://www.theguardian.com/technology/2022/mar/14/are-nfts-really-art> (Accessed on April 20, 2022).

Gopnik Blake, 'One Year After Beeple, the NFT Has Changed Artists. Has It Changed Art? Hardly at all.', *The New York Times*, <https://www.nytimes.com/2022/03/03/arts/design/nft-art-beeple.html> (Accessed April 20, 2022).

Price Seth, Kuo Michelle, 'What NFTs Mean for Contemporary Art', *MoMA Magazine*, Museum of Modern Art, New York, <https://www.moma.org/magazine/articles/547> (accessed April 20, 2022).

Johan, Pijnappel, edited. *Crossing Currents : Video Art and Cultural Identity*. New Delhi: Royal Netherlands Embassy, 2006.

Lovink, Geert. "Visit to Sarai New Media Centre." Geert Lovink, October 2002. Accessed April 17, 2022, <http://geertlovink.org/texts/visit-to-sarai-new-media-centre/>.

Sood, Pooja, edited. *The Khoj Book of Contemporary Indian Art: 1997-2007*. India: Harper Collins, 2010.

Sundaram, Ravi. *Pirate Modernity: Delhi's Media Urbanism*. Routledge, 2010

SPRING 2025

Electives

(All courses subject to change. All course schedules to be decided and announced)

On Photography – Histories, Theories, Practices

Course Code: VA 3018-1/MS-2239/SOA 3106-1

(Cross listed with Media Studies and Sociology/Anthropology)

Course Instructors: Rakhi Peswani and Sraman Mukherjee, Sraman Mukherjee for Spring 2025

Course Level- 3000 for Visual Arts and Sociology Anthropology and 2000 level

Elective course

Course Pre-requisites for students (if any): None. Only curiosity, interest in photography are desired.

Schedule: To be declared

Course Description:

This course will bring together image making histories, concerns, theories and practices, based on photographic techniques and technologies. The course will comprehensively introduce proto-photographic methods and re-trace those with modern and contemporary material as well as some nineteenth and twentieth century cultural reactions and theories of photographic image-forms. Considering its interdisciplinary nature, the media of photography will be introduced and explored through its contemporary usage as well as creative possibilities, bringing in perspectives from Art History, Visual Culture as well as artistic practice of the form.

Select Readings:

Mike Ware- Proto Photography and the Shroud of Turin

Peter Galassi – Before Photography

Walter Benjamin (1931) - Little History of Photography

Walter Benjamin (1936) – The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction

Christopher Pinney (1997) - *Camera Indica* (Chapter- Chamber of Dreams)

Susan Sontag (1973)- *On Photography* (Chapter- On Melancholy)

Additional Readings:

Roland Barthes (1980)- Camera Lucida- Reflections on Photography

Christopher Pinney (2004): Photos of the Gods : The Printed Image and Political Struggle in India

Susan Sontag (1977)- On Photography

John Berger (1972) – Ways of Seeing

Aileen Blaney and Chinar Shah (2018): Photography in India from archives to Contemporary Practice

Grading Rubric:

Cumulative grading through three assignments.

Each assignment will have components of practice plus one written essay based on a verbal or image prompt (Time frame : 4 weeks for each assignment.)

Each assignment will have a historical and theoretical framework to generate creative and investigative processes in the assignment.

Each assignment will have modules of a written essay and a practice oriented work. The rubrics will be :

40% practice

- Techniques in crafting of an image,
- Image structure and composition,
- Thematic concerns

40% essay

20% class participation

Learning outcomes:

1. To recognize and locate photographic image-making language as a nuanced process with historical and theoretical underpinnings.
2. To frame (reading) and craft (making) photographic practices from the discourse of technique, technology and aesthetics.
3. To discern and gain confidence in situating and making photographic image forms.

Attendance/ Participation Policy for students:

Up to 3 unannounced absences through the entire semester is permitted.

Course Title: In Situ: architecture, sculpture and painting in the Western Himalayas

Course Code: VA-3014/ SOA-3104/ HIS-3813-1

Course Instructor: Latika Gupta

Level of the Course: 1000/2000/3000

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: To be announced.

Course Description:

This course is an introduction to the architecture, sculpture and paintings of Buddhist temples and monasteries in the Western Himalayas, with a focus on extant sites in Ladakh and Himachal Pradesh. We will study major sites of art historical and cultural importance, while tracing their roots and interconnections to developments in art, religion, and aesthetics in Kashmir, Bihar and Tibet.

The course focuses on studying monasteries and temples through their geographical location, their usage, and changes in structure and style in response to religious and socio-political developments as well as changes in local ecological conditions. The artistic strategies employed, the material used in making paintings and sculptures will be explored in relation to their geographic, architectonic and spatial contexts as well as the ritual requirements of different schools of Buddhism in the region.

The course emphasises the importance and processes of place-making through history, mythology and local belief systems, and how these impact the relationship of communities with sites. We will also study the transformations that occur when sacred material culture is moved from its site of usage in the Himalayas to museum contexts. The course includes field trips to contemporary Buddhist sites in Delhi.

Learning Objectives:

By the end of this course, students:

- Will be conversant with major Tibetan Buddhist temples and monasteries in Ladakh and Himachal Pradesh.

- Will have the ability to ‘read’ sites as architectonic spaces, and study the architecture, sculptures and paintings in relation to their usage.
- Will be able to identify major deities of the Tibetan Buddhist pantheon and identify stylistic features of early Tibetan Buddhist art.
- Will be familiar with developments in the art of the region in conjunction with changes in religion and socio-political contexts of patronage.
- Will be able to write concise art historical notes in the nature of museum catalogue entries.

Course Deliverables:

The course will consist of illustrated lectures and seminars in which active participation will be expected of students. Readings for each seminar class will be assigned beforehand.

Students will deliver:

- Four art historical notes on chosen site/ sculpture/ painting + presentation (300 words each)
- End Semester Essay (2000 words including footnotes, bibliography)

Grading Rubrics:

Students will be graded on the basis of active participation in class seminars, on written assignments and a presentation.

- Class/ Seminar Participation: 20%
- Four art historical notes on chosen site/ sculpture/ painting (250 words each) + presentation: 40%
- End Semester essay (2000-2500 words including footnotes, bibliography): 40%

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted. However, since grading will be based on continuous assessment through the semester, absences during participative seminars and presentations will result in a reduction in the overall grade.

Select/ Preliminary Reading List:

- Brauen, Martin. The Mandala: Sacred Circle in Tibetan Buddhism. London: Serindia Publications, 1997.
- Bue, Erberto F Lo and Bray, John, Art and Architecture in Ladakh: Cross Cultural Transmissions in the Himalayas and Karakoram, Brill Tibetan Studies Library, 2014.
- Chandra, Yashaswini. “Art, Ritual and Belief at the Mrikula Devi Temple in Lahaul” in The Draw of the Hills, (Ed.) Latika Gupta, Marg Vol. 69 No.4, 2018
- Davidson, Ronald M. Indian Esoteric Buddhism: A Social History of the Tantric Movement, Motilal Banarsidass Publishers, 2003.
- Francke, A.H. A History of Western Tibet. Delhi: Pilgrim Books, 1999.

- Goepper, Roger and Jaroslav Poncar. *Alchi: Ladakh's Hidden Buddhist Sanctuary*. London: Serindia, 1996.
- Handa O.C. *Buddhist Monasteries in Himachal Pradesh*. New Delhi: Indus Publishing Company, 1987.
- Harrison, Peter. *Fortress Monasteries of the Himalayas: Tibet, Ladakh, Nepal and Bhutan*, Osprey Publishing, 2012.
- Heller, Amy. "Tracing the Impact of Kashmiri Art in Guge and Ladakh, Eleventh to Thirteenth centuries" *Inner and Central Asian Art and Archaeology II, New Research on Central Asian, Buddhist and Far Eastern Art and Archaeology*, 2019.
- Heller, Amy. *Early Himalayan Art*. Oxford: Ashmolean Museum, 2008.
- Heller, Amy. *Tibetan Art. Tracing the development of spiritual ideals and art in Tibet 600–2000 A.D.* Milano: Jaca Book, 1999.
- Heller, Amy and Giacomella Orefino (Eds.). *Discoveries in Western Tibet and the Western Himalayas*, Brill, 2007.
- Khosla, Romi. *Buddhist Monasteries in the Western Himalaya*. Kathmandu: Ratna Pustak Bhandar, 1979.
- Klimburg-Salter, Deborah E. *Tabo- A Lamp for the Kingdom- Early Indo-Tibetan Buddhist Art in the Western Himalaya*. Milan: Skira, 1997.
- Klimburg-Salter, Deborah E. *The Silk Route and the Diamond Path- Esoteric Art on the Trans-Himalayan Trade Route*. UCLA Arts Council, 1982.
- Konchog Lhadrepa, and Charlotte Davis. *The Art of Awakening: A User's Guide to Tibetan Buddhist Art and Practice*. Boulder: Snow Lion Publications, 2017.
- Linrothe, Rob (Ed.) *Collecting Paradise. Buddhist Art of Kashmir and Its Legacies*, edited by Rob Linrothe. New York & Evanston: Rubin Museum of Art, 2014.
- Linrothe, Rob and Jeff Watt. *Demonic Divine- Himalayan Art and Beyond*. Rubin Museum of Art, NY, Chicago: Serindia Publications, 2004.
- Lo Bue, Erberto F. "The Newar Artists of the Nepal Valley: A Historical Account of Their Activities in Neighbouring Areas with Particular Reference to Tibet." *Oriental Art* 31.3 (1985): 262–277.
- Lo Bue, Erberto F. "Cultural Exchange and Social Interaction between Tibetans and Newars from the Seventh to the Twentieth Century." *International Folklore Review* 6 (1988): 86–114.
- Lucanits, Christian. "From Tabo to Alchi: Revisiting Early Western Himalayan Art", *Oriental Art* 51, no. 5 (2020): 36-47.
- Lucanits, Christian. "Revival and Renaissance in Tibetan Art: Imagining Kashmir and Nepal in the Fifteenth and Seventeenth Centuries", *European Bulletin of Himalayan Research* 52, (2018): 93-131.
- Lucanits, Christian. *Buddhist Sculptures in Clay- Early Western Himalayan Art, Late 10th to early 13th centuries*. Chicago: Serindia Publications, 2004.

- Meister, Michael. “Mountain Temples and Temple-Mountains: Masrur” Journal of the Society of Architectural Historians, Vol. 65. No. 1 (March 2006), 26-49.
- Samuel, Geoffrey. Civilised Shamans: Buddhism in Tibetan Societies
- Samuel, Geoffrey. The Origins of Yoga and Tantra: Indic Religions to the 13th century, Cambridge University Press, 2013.
- Pal, Pratapaditya. Art from India, Nepal and Tibet, Philip Wilson Publishers Ltd., 2001.
- Siudmak, John. The Hindu-Buddhist Sculpture of Ancient Kashmir and its Influences. Brill, 2013.
- Snellgrove, David L. The Cultural Heritage of Ladakh. Warminster: Aris & Phillips, 1977.
- Snellgrove, David L. Indo-Tibetan Buddhism. Indian Buddhists and their Tibetan Successors. London: Serindia, 1987.
- Tucci, Giuseppe. Indo-Tibetica Series Vols. 1-7. Ed. Lokesh Chandra. New Delhi: Aditya Prakashan, 1988.

Course Title: Drawing as Extended Play

Course Instructor: Anni Kumari

Course Code: VA-3025/ MS-3253-1

Course Timings: To be declared

Course Level: 2000

Pre-requisites: None

Course Description:

Why draw? What do we draw? What do we draw from? Who do we draw for? What is the worth of a drawing? What is the relevance of drawing, today? This course examines the intersections between drawing and text, drawing and painting, drawing and photography, drawing and video, drawing and performance, and drawing and popular culture. In thinking of the everyday through the prism of theatrical reality, the course encourages inquiry about how drawings and the act of drawing itself is a dialogue about provisionality, uncertainty, and change. How do artists and artistic explorations address issues of meaning-making and shared history, politics, and culture? How do repetition, layering, overlapping, erasure, and incision transform an image, leading to alternative perspectives about how we perceive and engage with the known? How can we tell the same story in different material and socio-cultural contexts? Recognizing the importance of contradictions, ambiguity, and serendipity as integral to meaning-making processes, students have the flexibility to make interventions that can vary from poetic, polemic, dramatic, metaphorical, provocative, or incisive. You are encouraged to borrow from processes of scroll paintings, woodcut printmaking, comic books, experimental theatre, set design, photo performances, etc.

Learning Outcomes:

- Familiarity with histories of image making, reproduction, and consumption of images in popular media.

- Introduction to drawing as a visual language and a thinking medium with trans-disciplinary possibilities.
- Insight into how/ what individual artistic sensibilities lend to and borrow from mass media and visual culture.

Select Readings & Requirements (Reading List and other materials):

Modules

Module 1: Narrating and re-narrating

Duration-8 weeks

Class exercises will include the study of selected Kalighat paintings, Patua scroll paintings, Battala prints, Amar Chitra Katha stories, hand-painted posters of early Indian cinema, and set designs of Indigenous folk theatre. Students will be introduced to processes of drawing, printmaking, painting and graffiti as visual tools of storytelling.

References to Artists and their works: comics book series of Chitra Ganesh; site-specific drawings and installations of Nalini Malani

Reading References

Picture Showmen: Insights Into the Narrative Tradition in Indian Art. India: Marg Publications, 1998.

Blurton, T.R. 'The "Murshidabad" Pats of Bengal', Marg Publications, Vol. 49-3., 1998.

Singh, K. 'To Show, To See, To Tell, To Know: Patuas, Bhopas, and their Audiences', Marg Publication, Vol. 49(Issue no. 3), 1998.

Jain, Jyotindra. Kalighat painting: images from a changing world. India: Mapin Pub., 1999.

Archer, William George. Kalighat Paintings: A Catalogue and Introd. by W. G. Archer. United Kingdom: H.M. Stationery Office, 1971.

Kalighat Paintings: From the Collection of Victoria and Albert Museum, London and Victoria Memorial Hall, Kolkata. India: V&A Pub., 2011.

Guha-Thakurta, Tapati. The Making of a New 'Indian' Art: Artists, Aesthetics and Nationalism in Bengal, C.1850-1920. United Kingdom: Cambridge University Press, 1992.

References to Archives:

- PARI (People's Archive of Rural India)

https://ruralindiaonline.org/en/categories/?gad_source=1&gclid=CjwKCAiA29auBhBxEiwAnKcSqhX5adJ2BtfWmV3IQkGpT6yabFXMslufRa9xCQjL3KrCb83rHe32JhoCJbUQAvD_BwE

- Victoria & Albert Museum

<https://www.vam.ac.uk/articles/kalighat-painting#slideshow=4207388&slide=0>

- MAP (Museum of Art & Photography)

<https://artsandculture.google.com/story/from-under-the-banyan-tree-to-the-world-museum-of-art-photography/VwUBj8rAy6wqIw?hl=en>

Materials required: Sketchbook, Cartridge Sheets, Graded pencils (B, 2B, and 4B), Indian ink, Charcoal & Watercolours

Assignment 1: Submission of 6 drawings based on stories from the PARI archive +2 painted scrolls based on references from the Patua scroll painting tradition+ 2 prints (one print in Black and white and another in color). All submissions must be made on Google Classroom as well as in hard copies.

Module 2: Performing the Image

Duration -4 weeks

Class exercises will involve archival research and visit to the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), the Crafts Museum, the Partition Museum and the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art. Students will have the opportunity to work with digital mediums (including DSLR cameras and Wacom Tablet) and experiment with process that involve the use of an inhouse Electric Sewing Machine and a Printing Press.

Frameworks: Situating the body; masquerading and seduction; entry and exit points; points of intersections; colonial history and Euro-centric sensibilities; the protagonist and the provocateur.

References to Artists and their works: Ethnographic series of photo-performances by Pushpamala N; drawing-based performances by Nikhil Chopra

Reading References:

Pinney, Christopher. Photography and Anthropology. India: Oxford University Press (India), 2011.

Pinney, Christopher. Photo Studio. India: Photoink, 2018.

India's Popular Culture: Iconic Spaces and Fluid Images. India: Marg Publications, 2007.

Majumdar, Rochona. Art Cinema and India's Forgotten Futures: Film and History in the Postcolony. United States: Columbia University Press, 2021.

References to Archives:

- Sarmaya Foundation

<https://sarmaya.in/spotlight/who-is-an-indian-crafting-identity-through-photography/>

- Asia Art Archive

<https://aaa.org.hk/en/like-a-fever/like-a-fever/propositions-for-an-archive-of-performance-art-in-india>

- Critical Collective

https://criticalcollective.in/Lens_based_practic.aspx

<https://criticalcollective.in/Cinema.aspx?tid=21>

Assignment 2: Students are expected to work on a collective project drawing from the experience of engaging with the archives, and devising personal strategies and methodologies for engaging with a specific theme.

Grading Rubric:

Mid-Term Assessment: Class exercises (10%) +Assignment 1(40%)

End semester assessment: Class participation (20%) + Assignment 2(30%)

Course Deliverables: Physical copies of works & photo documentation of class assignments and the different stages of the project-making process.

Attendance Policy:

Up to two absences need no prior approval or medical documentation.

**Course Title: Curating Contemporary Art: From Artists' Studios to Exhibition Making
Spring 2025**

Course Instructor: Srinivas Aditya Mopidevi

Course Code: VA 3013

Course Level: Undergraduate / Graduate - Level 3000

Prerequisites: None

Schedule: To be announced

Course Description:

This course introduces the students to the practical skills and conceptual methodologies of curating with particular emphasis on contemporary art. From being a custodian of art in a museum, the role of the curator has diversified extensively in the past decades to a new dynamic of cultural production and collaboration between the artists and curators. By beginning with the history of curatorial practice and the figure of the curator, this course will offer students an initial grounding on curatorial practices and models globally. It will unpack the challenges and possibilities of art institutions such as private galleries, museums, non-profit organizations, and Biennales. Further, it will investigate with case studies the methods of curating art that does not fit into the neat institutional definitions.

In this part-theoretical and part-practical course, the students will also learn hands-on procedures of curating: research, fundraising, management, design, publicity, exhibition making, and producing a publication. With studio exercises and interim collaborations with artists and art institutions in India, the course aims to enable the students to discover their niche in the potentiality offered by the methods of curating.

Learning Objectives:

By the end of this course, students:

Will be well versed in the diverse practical and conceptual methods of curating.

Will develop an understanding of contemporary art and its multiple forms of public engagement.

Will develop a critical eye towards looking at artistic practice from a curatorial perspective.
Will learn the process of ideating, planning, and executing a curatorial project.

Course Deliverables:

The course will consist of illustrated lectures, seminars and hands-on workshops in which active participation will be expected of students.

Students will deliver:

One 500-word case study of any exhibition that resonates with them.

One presentation delving deep into a curatorial format of their choice.

A final exhibition / presentation co-curated by the students of the course advised by the course instructor. (*The material for the final exhibition / presentation can be sourced from any artist, institution across the world contingent on the resources available at the department and university.)

Grading Rubrics:

Students will be graded on the basis of active participation in class, their choice of presentation topics, written components as well as the realization of the final project.

Class/ Seminar Participation: 20%

One 500 word case study of an exhibition that resonated with the students - 15 %

One presentation on the curatorial format of their choice. 15%

Final exhibition / presentation (individual or group project format): 50 %

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted. However, since grading will be based on continuous assessment through the semester, absences during participative seminars and presentations will result in a reduction in the overall grade.

Select Readings:

Irit Rogoff, "The Expanding Field," *Yishu: Journal of Contemporary Chinese Art*, Vancouver, Vol. 13 No. 2.

Irit Rogoff, "Smuggling: An Embodied Criticality," (<http://transform.eipcp.net/transversal/0806/rogoff1/en>) (accessed 10 July 2012).

Paul O'Neill ed., *The Culture of Curating and the Curating of Culture(s)*, MIT Press, Massachusetts 2016.

Sara Cook and Beryl Graham. *Rethinking Curating: Art After New Media*. London: The MIT Press, Massachusetts, 2010.

Raqs Media Collective, *INSERT2014*, Exhibition Publication, New Delhi, 2014.

Raqs Media Collective, *Why Not Ask Again?* - 11th Shanghai Biennale, Exhibition Publication, Power Station of Art, Shanghai, 2016.

Kochi Muziris Biennale, Exhibition Publication, 2012, 2014, 2016, 2018, 2022, Kochi Biennale Foundation, Kochi, 2012-2021.

Naman P Ahuja, *The Body In Indian Art And Thought*, Ludion, 2014.

Annapurna Garimella ed., *Vernacular in the Contemporary 1 & 2*, Exhibition Publications, Devi Art Foundation, Gurgaon, 2010-11.

Okwui Enwezor, *All the World's Futures*, Exhibition Publication, Biennale Di Venezia, Venice, 2015.

Chika Okeke-Agulu, Jane Chin Davidson, Alpesh Kantilal Patel ed., *Okwui Enwezor: The Art of Curating*, Duke University Press, 2021.

Gabi Ngcobo, *We Don't Need Another Hero* - 10th Berlin Biennale, Exhibition Publication, KW Berlin, 2018.

Naman Ahuja, Parul Dave Mukherji and Kavita Singh ed., *Influx: Contemporary Art in Asia*, Sage, New Delhi, 2014.

Beatrice Von Bismarch, Jorn Schafaff, Thomas Weski ed., *Cultures of the Curatorial*, Sternberg Press, 2012.

ruangrupa, *Lumbung* - Documenta 15, Exhibition Publication, Hatje Cantz, Kassel, 2022.

Pooja Sood ed., *The Khoj Book 1997-2007: Contemporary Art Practice in India*, Harper Collins, India, 2010.

Sarai Reader Series 1 - 9 (2001-2013), Sarai Media Lab - Centre for Studies in Developing Societies, New Delhi.

Kavita Singh, Shukla Sawant, and Naman Ahuja + Students of School of Arts and Aesthetics, JNU, *Where in the World*, Exhibition Publication, Devi Art Foundation, Gurgaon, 2008-09.

Jean Hubert Martin, *Magiciens de la terre*, Exhibition Publication, Centre Pompidou, Paris, 1989.

Maura Reilly, and Lucy Lippard ed., *Curatorial Activism: Towards an Ethics of Curating*, Thames & Hudson, London, 2018.

Visualizing from the Archive

Exploring the Ashoka Archive through visual storytelling

Course Code: VA-2052/ MS-2052

Course Instructor: Vishwajyoti Ghosh [vishwajyoti.ghosh@ashoka.edu.in]

Semester: Spring

Attendance Policy: 90% minimum attendance

Prerequisites: Narrative based research, writing, basic drawing/ doodling, basic research photography, basic mobile photography.

Course description:

Exploring the Ashoka Archives: The Ashoka Archives is building up to offer an incredible wealth of knowledge, stories, experiences, correspondences, and images. It's truly astonishing that such an amazing resource is now on campus. As an educational institution, it's exceptionally vital to emphasize that without an archive, a significant portion of cultural history, can get lost due to various reasons.

Centred around the Ashoka Archives, this course aims to delve into distinctive viewpoints of scholars through active engagement with archives and the materials that pique their individual interests. Scholars will also delve into the dual role of archives, serving as both tools and points of reference for shaping their artistic and storytelling visions. A primary emphasis of the program will be to openly and candidly investigate how archival materials can be harnessed to spark new artistic possibilities. Through art, visual storytelling, graphic narratives, there's an opportunity for the scholars to reinvigorate and re-examine the information available but also to generate new creations and events that can themselves be archived, allowing the scholar artists to contribute their unique voices to the historical record.

Archives are like a time capsule, preserving the past. They're unique to individuals, organisations and specific periods in history, so no two archives are the same. They serve as a reminder of everything we might forget but should always remember. Archives hold a special power because archives act as the keepers of our collective memories, providing a glimpse into the worlds of writers, artists, thinkers and organisations, that helps us understand the different worlds where the materials in the archives come from. They're like hidden treasure troves for storytelling enthusiasts, creative minds, artists and scholars.

What this course is about

The fundamental concept here is to utilize the Ashoka Archive as a platform for artistic discussion and intellectual exchange. This will offer not only the institution but also scholars and practitioners a chance to develop fresh, critical, and imaginative methods to engage the public. This engagement

will be based on the materials found in the Ashoka Archive. The emphasis lies on both the Archive itself and individual scholars, who will collaboratively produce knowledge, visual narratives, and expertise. The process is as crucial as the final results, ensuring that visual exploration aligns seamlessly with the creation of knowledge and artistic expression.

The course is designed to empower scholars in conjunction with the Archive over a single semester:

- **Creative Documentation:** These projects will focus on creating content to enrich the archive's knowledge repository, ultimately leading to tangible outcomes such as mini-books, zines, and catalogues.
- **Creative Projects:** These initiatives aim to support creative expressions that interpret the archive's collections through visual stories, comics, artwork, and other artistic endeavours.

This approach can help the scholars in negotiating their findings, research and learnings through visual interpretations in multi-disciplinary formats that is much required in today's realm of information & content, where visual storytelling is an alternate and a popular form of information, opinion and communication.

Learning objectives:

These learning objectives will guide scholars through the course, enabling them to not only delve into the archival materials available but also develop a skill set that combines historical interpretation, visual storytelling, and ethical considerations in presenting interpreted narratives inspired from the archive.

Understanding Archives: Define the concept of archives and their significance in preserving historical records. Explain the role of university archives in the history making and the process of documentation within the framework of an academic institution.

Research and Selection: Develop the skills to identify and select relevant materials from the university archive. Distinguish between primary and secondary sources and understand the value of primary materials in historical research.

Visual Analysis: Learn to critically analyse visual materials, including photographs, documents, and artifacts. Identify key elements of visual analysis, such as authorship, date, context, and significance.

Material Context: Gain an understanding of the historical context in which the selected materials were created. Recognize the broader historical events and societal influences that may have shaped the materials.

Visual Storytelling: Master the principles of visual storytelling, including design, composition, and narrative. Develop the ability to create visually engaging and informative materials based on historical content. Explore the use of digital tools and design software for creating visual materials. Learn to articulate the stories and insights conveyed through visual interpretation.

Ethical Considerations: Explore the ethical considerations when working with historical materials, including issues related to copyright, privacy, and cultural sensitivity. Learn to handle and cite archival materials with integrity and respect for the rights of individuals involved.

Interdisciplinary Skills: Encourage interdisciplinary thinking by connecting historical materials with various academic disciplines. Foster the ability to draw insights and connections between archival content and other fields of study.

Reflection and Analysis: Encourage critical thinking by reflecting on the impact of visual interpretation on historical understanding. Analyse the choices made during the interpretation process and their implications.

Collaboration and Peer Review: Foster collaboration by engaging in peer review and constructive feedback with fellow students. Learn from others' interpretations and perspectives.

+ Final Project:

Apply the knowledge and skills acquired throughout the course to create a final visual interpretation project using materials from the university archive.

Present the project to the class, showcasing the historical context, significance, and storytelling elements.

Course modules:

The proposed modules aim to provide scholars with valuable skills in archival research, critical analysis, visual design, and storytelling while fostering a deeper connection to their university's archive and the materials available. The idea would be in exploring from the diversity of materials to create diversity of practice involved in visual interpretations. The core idea here will be to discuss the materials available to create forms and works that can bring new practice-based influences and ideas, their working process and explore the architecture of visual storytelling in these works.

Weeks 1-2: Introduction and understanding the University Archive

In this initial module, scholars will be introduced to the concept of university archive. They will gain an understanding of what these archives are, why they are essential for preserving historical records, and how they play a significant role in documenting academic works, arts, historical materials etc.

Weeks 2-3: Understanding the Archives & Research Skills and Selection

Scholars will be initiated with practical skills for conducting archival research. They will receive hands-on guidance on searching for materials within the university archive's catalogue or database. The module will emphasize the importance of reliable sources and the value of primary documents in historical research. Scholars will be encouraged to select a specific topic or theme related to their interest or a particular collection within the archive.

Weeks 3-4: Selection of material + Analysing and Placing in Context

In this module, the focus will be on how to critically analyse the materials selected by the scholars. They will delve into key elements of analysis, including authorship, date, context, and significance. Additionally, they will explore historical context, including the important events, and the broader historical backdrop. Scholars will be encouraged to ask probing questions about the materials they're examining and to uncover the stories and insights they hold. Scholars will also be sensitised how to handle and cite archival materials appropriately, with a strong emphasis on giving credit to the source and respecting the rights and privacy of individuals involved.

Week 5: Presentation of final material selected + their visual ideas

Selection and research of interesting archival material will be followed to process and distill the findings to create the core conceptual idea and be presented in the studio sessions for the benefit of collective brainstorming and discussions. These discussions with fellow classmates will lead to an inter-disciplinary ideation and conceptualization, moving closer to shape and sharpen the core project ideas of the scholars. The scholars will also be expected to share the processing of their research findings along with their influences and inspirations.

Weeks 6-7: Mastering Visual Storytelling

Moving on from research, the course will now discuss the working process of creating a visual narrative using multiple influences of form and genres. This will include detailed discussions on the various possibilities of the form i.e., different forms that can be explored - doodle narratives, popular comics, mobile based narratives, photo comics, design, layouts, page architecture, typography, sequential storytelling and the work process involved in each, enabling the students to make informed choices in sync with their ideas. Students will explore various tools and software for creating visual materials, and they'll discuss the strengths and limitations of popular software including open-source alternatives. Practical exercises will be provided to enable students to create engaging and informative visual materials, which may include designing innarratives, zines, or digital outputs.

Week 8: Presentation of a final project draft followed by discussion on similar ideas & influences

The following week the students will be expected to present their ideas and preliminary drafts as scribbles/ sketches with fellow batchmates, followed by open discussions, suggestions and ideation to evolve a clear understanding to flesh out the final narrative. Peer review and discussion will be encouraged to facilitate mutual learning. Each scholar/ project will be further exposed to similar works through display and in-depth discussions on influences and ideas related to the project to lend a visual and storytelling perspective, enabling the practitioner to take one's work further.

Besides creating multiple micro narratives through the semester, finally, the semester will move to its last weeks to create a bigger multi-page graphic narrative.

Weeks 9-14: Final completion with a mid-level presentation in week 8.

A mid-level draft presentation will be shared in the studio to display the work in progress after 2 weeks then followed by the final 4 weeks or the end of the semester, ready for display, presentation and production. Studio presence in these weeks will be a must.

Output participation:

Though the output will be individual, the process of production will be based on archival research, short studio collaborations and conversations and work-in-progress presentations at regular intervals as discussed above.

Course deliverables:

Every student will be expected to develop, produce multiple research-based short visual stories and graphic narratives/ comics.

Grading Rubric:

Scholars will be assessed based on their ability to select, analyse, and create visual materials. Assessment criteria may include the depth of research analysis, quality of their visual materials and their adherence to ethical guidelines. Presentations and students' participation in discussions will also be considered in their evaluation.

Conceptual clarity & Research – 20%

Ability to understand concepts comprehensively, remember and articulate them. Pursuing research to acquire broader understanding. Relating acquired knowledge to improve information organisation. The ability to fully comprehend, remember, and communicate concepts.

Originality & Visualization – 20%

The ability to come up with original ideas inspired from the archival material, the skill to articulate visually.

Exploration, Execution– 40%

Ability to deeply enquire a wide variety of explorations and bring it into practice. To improvise and pivot when required. The journey from visualisation to final execution.

Problem Solving & Improvisation -10%

Having a methodological approach to address visual challenges. The willingness to connect ones academic practice and those notions to one's own work.

Teamwork, Class Participation, Time Management -10%

Efficiency and the capacity to manage time and participates in joint feedback sessions, collective display and collective work effectively

Preliminary reading list:

1. "Archives: Principles and Practices" by Laura A. Millar
2. "The Archive Effect: Found Footage and the Audiovisual Experience of History" by Jaimie Baron
3. Digital memory and the Archive by Wolfgang Ernst

4. Archive Fever: Uses of the Document in Contemporary Art by Okwui Enwezor
 5. Managing Archival and Manuscript Repositories by Michael J. Kurtz
 6. Visual Explanations: Images and Quantities, Evidence and Narrative by Edward R. Tufte
 7. Design for Information: An Introduction to the Histories, Theories, and Best Practices Behind Effective Information Visualizations by Isabel Meirelles
 8. Access to History: The Archive and the User by David Thomas, Simon Fowler, and Valerie Johnson
 9. Copyright for Archivists and Records Managers by Tim Padfield
 10. The New Historicism and Other Old-Fashioned Topics by Arnold Rampersad
 11. Information Design Workbook: Graphic Approaches, Solutions, and Inspiration + 30 Case Studies by Kim Baer
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Built Environments, Design and the Architectural Imagination of Sultanate and Mughal Cities from the 13th to the 17th centuries

Course Code: VA-2345

Course Instructor: Priyani Roy Choudhury

Course Level: 2000-3000

Prerequisites: None

Course Description:

This course examines the making of cities during the Sultanate and early Mughal periods. Students will learn to interpret architecture as both cultural expression and technical accomplishment. The creation of a city reflects a society's power, wealth, knowledge, and imagination, often embodying its aspirations through the built environment, spatial organization, and ecological relationships. In Islamicate cultures moreover, oral narratives, Sufi lyric traditions, and illustrated manuscripts are crucial in defining cities. They shape the discourses through which cities are perceived and remembered. This course integrates architectural, visual, poetic, and narrative materials that inform the spatial imagination of early modern South Asian cities.

Learning Outcomes:

- Understand the cultural exchange and innovation that defined Sultanate and Mughal Architecture.
- Analyse how local and global influences, and environmental factors intersect in urban design.
- Explore the representation of cities in art, literature, and history.

Two Onsite Workshops (Itineraries subject to modifications)

1. Tughlaqabad, Tomb of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq, Begampuri Masjid/Khirki Masjid, Kotla Firoz Shah/Hauz Khas (Date: Early/Mid-February). The Tughlaq heritage of Delhi is pivotal to understanding the evolution of planned cities in the region. However, it is often overlooked in architectural histories, which tend to focus on early Sultanate and Mughal architecture. The workshop will aim to bring this heritage into focus.
2. Agrasen ki Baoli, Dinapanah (Purana Qila), Khair-ul Manzil (Maham Anga's Mosque), Monuments within Lodhi Gardens/ Humayun's Tomb Complex (Date: Early March, before mid-semester break). This workshop will provide an understanding of the diverse functions of urban structures such as stepwells, forts, mosques, and tombs, while exploring mid-16th century Delhi's architectural transition between Lodhi, Suri, and early Mughal styles.

Grading Rubric:

Students will be graded on a continuous basis:

- Class participation and discussions (10%)
- Class/Site presentation (25%)
- Worksheets (25%)
- End of Term Research paper or Project (40%)

Attendance Policy:

After week 2, three absences will be allowed. Notified leaves will be allowed on a case-by-case basis.

Primary Literature:

Short Excerpts from poems of Amir Khusro Dehlavi and Amir Hasan Dehlavi

Rahim, Abdur. *Nagar Shobha*-A Brajbhasha Poem (Selected Passages)

<https://hindi-kavita.com/HindiNagarShobhaRahim.php>

General Bibliography:

Burton-Page, John. *Indian Islamic Architecture: Forms and Typologies, Sites and Monuments*. Edited by George Michell. Leiden; Boston: Brill, 2008.

Grabar, Oleg. *The Mediation of Ornament*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1992.

Hays, K. Michael. "Aesthetic Perception and the Architectural Imagination." Harvard Online. YouTube video, April 2017. https://m.youtube.com/watch?v=PY_Hsw4BYpY .

Kumar, Sunil. *The Emergence of the Delhi Sultanate, 1192-1286*. India: Permanent Black, 2007.

Mukhia, Harbans. *The Mughals of India*. Germany: Wiley, 2008.

Rau, Susanne. "Urbanity (urbanitas, Urbanität, urbanité, urbanità, urbanidad...) — An Essay " In *Religion and Urbanity Online* edited by Susanne Rau and Jörg Rüpke. Berlin, Boston: De Gruyter, 2020. <https://doi.org/10.1515/urbrel.11276000>

Taneja, Anand Vivek. *Jinnealogy: Time, Islam, and Ecological Thought in the Medieval Ruins of Delhi. South Asia in Motion*. Stanford: Stanford University Press, 2017.

Compulsory course for Students Writing Art History UG Thesis offered as ISM in Monsoon 2024:

Methods in Art History

Course Code: VA-IS-4003-1

Course Instructor: Sraman Mukherjee

Course Level: 4000

Course Specifics: Compulsory ISM for students pursuing Undergraduate (ASP) Capstone/ 4th year thesis in Visual Arts, especially Art History. The ISM is open to students whose 4th year/ Capstone thesis is

Prerequisites: Students should have completed at least two 2000 level courses in Visual Arts.

ISM Description

This ISM introduces theories and methods of art history that have played a major role in its intellectual and professional formation of the discipline. From the pre-disciplinary cusp of Vasari and artistic biographies in the Renaissance, the course will explore the origins of art historical scholarship in the eighteenth century, and then touch on a wide range of subsequent approaches, including Marxist, feminist, and post-colonial interpretations of art. The ISM approaches the discipline of art history as an archival mediated site of cultural critique and construction. Special attention will be given to the adequacy of established art-historical paradigms of formal, stylistic, and iconographic analysis in dealing with the “expanded field” of visual studies. Keeping in mind the research interests of students, the ISM will introduce the student/s to various ways of reading archival traces and sources beyond the North Atlantic context and problematize the professional structure of art history and visual studies as an increasingly “globalized” mode of inquiry.

Topics to be discussed as seminar discussions

- Rethinking a pre-disciplinary moment: Vasari's *Lives*
- Mining for Histories and the Genesis of a Discipline
- Semiotic Turn
- Orientalism and Art History in India
- Reading Archives: Sources, Traces
- Visual Images as Traces and Archives
- Marxist Turn
- Deconstructing Art History
- New Historicism
- Gendering Art History: Feminism and Queer Studies
- Postmodernism
- Anthropology as Art (History)
- Ecologies of Art History

Grading rubric:

Students will be assessed quarterly based on their engagement with the readings which will carry 50% of the course grades.

The end semester assessment will comprise of the students' submission of their final research proposal clearly outlining the methods and scope of their thesis with an complete annotated bibliography of primary resources and published literature and plan of thesis to be completed during Spring semester 2025. This will carry 50% of the course grades.

Learning Outcome:

The ISM is designed to help MLS and ASP Capstone students in Visual Arts formalize their research proposals and develop their specific research skills for writing their thesis in Art History over the academic year 2024-25.

Source Books:

Donald Preziosi, ed. *The Art of Art History: A Critical Anthology*. New York: Oxford University Press. 1998

Robert Nelson and Richard Shiff eds. *Critical Terms for Art History* (Chicago: Chicago University Press, second edition, 2003

Eric Fernie ed. *Art History and its Methods: A Critical Anthology*. London: Phaidon, fourth edition, 1999

Other Electives not on offer at the moment

(Not on offer in 2024-25, but available in the department catalogue in past and perhaps in future, depending on faculty availability)

Arts, Crafts and Performative practices from Central India: Chartering Identities

Course Code: VA 3001/PA 3009

(Spring Semester 2024)

Course Instructor: Preeti Bahadur Ramaswami

Course Level: 3000

Course description:

This course will focus on critically examining trajectories in artisanal and performative practices from the region of central India in post-Independence India. The states of Madhya Pradesh and the recently created state of Chhattisgarh will form the ambit of discussions. The course will acquaint students with case histories of practitioners, to trace trajectories of transformation. It will engage with questions of caste and community, agency and selfhood to understand the shaping of art forms and their contexts as well as the role and modes of interventions in these practices, including the work of anthropologists, scholars, museums and institutions, and the market. Students will critically engage with discourses surrounding the representation of these forms, including the binaries of art versus craft, or the categories of folk and tribal.

Learning outcomes:

What are the forces that shape the lives and practices of individuals referred to in public discourse as craftsmen, or 'folk' and 'tribal' artists in post-independence India? How much agency do they

have over their lives and practice and to what extent are they ‘manipulated’ by ‘outside’ mediators? How do caste and community shape their practice, and to what extent is it transformed when negotiating spaces beyond traditional contexts? And how do tradition and modernity parley with each other in the shaping of their careers? This course is designed to make students actively debate and engage with these issues and beyond, through case studies of practitioners of both crafts and performative practices from Central India. Oral epics, metal sculptures, clay reliefs, ‘Gond’ painting, body art (tattooing) are some of the practices that will form the focus of discussion. Students will also examine shifts in representation in museums and exhibitions and debate them.

Grading rubric:

Students will be assessed continually through the entire semester including active class participation, mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading pattern will broadly be as follows:

Class participation and engagement : 10% of total grades.

Class presentations and mid semester assignment: 60% of total grades.

End semester paper/ essay: 30% of total grades.

Readings:

Gregory, Christopher A. "Chhattisgarh: At the crossroads." *The Modern Anthropology of India*. Routledge, 2013. 60-79.

Lamb, Ramdas. *Rapt in the Name: The Ramnamis, Ramnam, and Untouchable Religion in Central India*. SUNY Press, 2002

Nalini Sundar, *Subalterns and Sovereigns: An Anthropological History of Bastar*, (OUP) , 2008.

Varma, Rashmi. "Primitive Accumulation: The Political Economy of Indigenous Art in Postcolonial India." *Third Text* 27.6 (2013): 748-761.

Joyce Burkhalter Flueckigner, *Gender and Genre in the Folklore of Middle India*, (Cornell University Press, Ithaca, London) 1996.

Gregory, Chris A. "The oral epics of the women of the Dandakaranya Plateau: a preliminary mapping." *Journal of Social Sciences* 8.2 (2004): 93-104.

Hacker, Katherine F. "Traveling Objects: Brass Images, Artisans, and Audiences." *Res: Anthropology and Aesthetics* 37.1 (2000): 147-165.

Hacker, Katherine. "The ‘Possessed’ Body: Siraha, Swings, and Performing Difference in Bastar, Central India." *Dialogues with Gods: Possession in Middle Indian Rituals*, ed. Tina Otten and Uwe Skoda (Berlin: Weissensee Verlag, 2014): 193-229.

Chatterji, Roma. *Speaking with pictures: Folk art and the narrative tradition in India*. Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2016.

Garimella, Annapurna. "A Tree Grows in a Painting: Tribal Artists and the Museum." *MARG-A MAGAZINE OF THE ARTS* 71.3 (2020): 40-51.

Garimella, Annapurna, ed. *Vernacular in the Contemporary 1*. Devi Art Foundation, 2010.

Swaminathan, Jagdish. "Art and the Adivasi." *India International Centre Quarterly* 19.1/2 (1992): 113-127.

Hacker, Katherine. "Dismantling or Rehabilitating the Cult of the Craftsman Paradigm: Some Reflections on Jaidev Baghel's Practice." *The Journal of Modern Craft* 9.2 (2016): 139-159

Jyotindra Jain, *Other Masters: Five Contemporary Folk and Tribal Artists of India* (Crafts Museum) 1998.

Jyotindra Jain, *Jangarh Singh Shyam: A Conjurer's Archive* (Mapin), 2019.

Chatterji, Roma. *Op.cit*

Swaminathan, Jagdish. "Art and the Adivasi." *India International Centre Quarterly* 19.1/2 (1992): 113-127.

Jain, Jyotindra. "Women Artists of Rural India." *Women of India: Colonial and Post-Colonial Periods* ('History of Science, Philosophy and Culture in Indian Civilization', 9.3 (2005): 501-523.

Hacker, Katherine F. "Displaying a Tribal Imaginary: Known and Unknown India." *Museum Anthropology* 23.3 (2000): 5-25.

Luis, Sandip K. "Between Anthropology and History: The Entangled Lives of Jangarh Singh Shyam and Jagdish Swaminathan." *Intersections of Contemporary Art, Anthropology and Art History in South Asia*. Palgrave Macmillan, Cham, 2019. 139-179.

Dalmia, V. . Folk Theatre and the Search for an Indigenous Idiom:: Brecht in India. In *Poetics, Plays, and Performances: The Politics of Modern Indian Theatre*. : Oxford University Press, 2008. <https://www.oxfordscholarship.com/view/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780195695052.001.0001/acprof-9780195695052-chapter->

Ramchandra Guha, *Verrier Elwin: His Tribals and India*, Penguin, 2016.

Hacker, Katherine. "" A Simultaneous Validity of Co-Existing Cultures": J. Swaminathan, the Bharat Bhavan, and Contemporaneity." *Archives of Asian Art* 64.2 (2014): 191-209.

Gregory, Chris A. *Savage money: the anthropology and politics of commodity exchange*. Vol. 21. Taylor & Francis, 1997.

Sanjay Srivastava et al. *Critical Themes in Indian Sociology*, (Sage) 2019.

Gayatri Sinha, Ed. *Expressions and Evocations: Contemporary Women Artists in India*, (Marg) , 1996.

Bharat Ray Ed. *Women Of India: Colonial and Post -Colonial Periods* (Sage) 2005

Singh, Kavita, Mathur Saloni, *No touching, No spitting, No praying: the Museum in South Asia* (Routledge) 2017.

Perera, Sasanka, and Dev Nath Pathak, eds. *Intersections of Contemporary Art, Anthropology and Art History in South Asia: Decoding Visual Worlds*. Springer, 2019.

Price, Sally. "The Enduring Power of Primitivism: Showcasing “the Other” in Twenty-First-Century France." *A Companion to Modern African Art* (2013): 445-465.

Kramrisch, Stella. *Unknown India: Ritual art in tribe and village*. Museum of Art, 1968.

Course Title: *Collectivism in Art: Nodes from the 20th and early 21st Century*

Course Instructor: Srinivas Aditya Mopidevi

Level of the Course: Undergraduate

Prerequisites: None

Course Description:

This course introduces students to the multifaceted idea of the collective in artistic practices of the 20th and early 21st centuries. It unpacks how the idea of collective and collectivity evolved amid a diverse set of historical, cultural, and political contingencies in different parts of the world. From the Vernacular practices of art in India to The Situationist International in Europe, the idea of what constitutes a collective has seen radical shifts and transformations. Collectivism after Modernism, for instance, embraced the heterogeneous character of cultural formations and contested the established notions of individual artistic genius. The collectives that formed in the wake of the internet such as Sarai (New Delhi) began thinking beyond the framework of the nation-state with newly networked cultural communities across the world. At the same time, there are contemporary art collectives like the Gulf Labor Coalition, a temporary group of artists from New York who came together to fight for the betterment of labor conditions in the United Arab Emirates.

With an overview of collectivism in the 20th and early 21st Century, this course will unpack the radical potential and limitations of collective formations of the world. The geographical scope of the discussions will include South Asia, Aboriginal Australia, Indonesia, Russia, Japan to mention a few. The course aims to provide the students with a comprehensive idea of what it means to be a collective in the turbulent times we live in.

Learning Objectives:

By the end of this course, students:

- Will be well versed in the idea of collective and collectivism in the 20th and early 21st Century.
- Will develop an understanding of art movements such as Futurism, Dadaism, as well as the idea of collective in Vernacular practices of India and Aboriginal Australia.
- Will understand from a historical perspective the significance and limitations of a collective, especially in the turbulent times we live in.
- Will be informed enough to embrace the idea of micro and macro creative collectives within the student community at Ashoka.

Course Deliverables:

The course will consist of illustrated lectures and seminars in which active participation will be expected of students. Readings and visual material for each seminar class will be assigned beforehand.

Students will deliver:

- Three 500 word case studies on a collective of their choice.
- A final project developed in groups. Submissions include a 1000 word group manifesto and a final project presentation (exhibition, film, essay).

Grading Rubrics:

Students will be graded on the basis of active participation in class seminars, their choice of topics, written components as well as the final project.

- Class/ Seminar Participation: 20%
- Three 500 word case studies on a collective of their choice: 40%
- Final project (1000 word group manifesto and a final project presentation): 40%

Attendance Policy:

Three absences are permitted. However, since grading will be based on continuous assessment through the semester, absences during participative seminars and presentations will result in a reduction in the overall grade.

Select/ Preliminary Reading List:

- Stimson Blake & Sholette Gregory Ed., *Collectivism After Modernism: The Art of Social Imagination after 1945*, University of Minnesota Press, Minneapolis, 2004.
- Grant H. Kester, *The One and the Many: Contemporary Collaborative Art in a Global Context*, Duke University Press, 2011.
- Parimoo Ratan and Bhagwat Nalini, 'The Spirit of the 1940s and 1950s', *Art Etc – News & Views*, <http://www.artnewsnviews.com/view-article.php?article=progressive-artists-group-of-bombay-an-overview&iid=29&articleid=800>. (Accessed December 14, 2021).
- Bordewekar Sandhya, 'Group 1890: An Antidote for the Progressives?', *Art Etc, News & Views*, <http://www.artnewsnviews.com/view-article.php?article=group-1890-an-antidote-for-the-progressives&iid=30&articleid=849#sthash.roO9iDkK.dpu>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- David Teh, *Travelling Without Moving*, *Third Text*, Vol 26, Issue 5, 567-583, <http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/09528822.2012.712773>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Kapur Geeta, 'Curating Across Agnostic Worlds', in Mukherji, Ahuja and Singh Ed., *Influx: Contemporary Art in Asia*, Sage Publications, Delhi, 2014.
- Friday Review, 'The art contemporaries', *The Hindu*, <http://www.thehindu.com/features/friday-review/art/the-art-contemporaries/article4252884.ece>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Delhi Silpi Chakra, *Critical Collective*, <http://www.criticalcollective.in/ArtistGInner2.aspx?Aid=224&Eid=199>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Periferry. "Vision." *Perriferry 1.0*. http://www.periferry.in/about_vision.html. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Poddar, Sandhini. "Desiring Machines." *Art India* Vol. 16, quarterly 3, no. 3, 2012.

- Raqs Media Collective, 'A Concise Lexicon Of / For the Digital Commons', Sarai Reader: Shaping Technologies, New Delhi, 2003.
- Raqs Media Collective, Seepage, Sternberg Press, Berlin, 2010.
- Rowan Wilken, A Community of Strangers? Mobile Media, Art, Tactility and Urban Encounters with the Other, Mobilities, <http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/17450101.2010.510330>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Sood, Pooja, Ed., The Khoj Book of Contemporary Indian Art: 1997-2007. Harper Collins, India, 2010.
- Lind Maria and Steyerl Hito Ed., *The Green Room: Reconsidering the Documentary and Contemporary Art #1*, Sternberg Press, 2008.
- Tiziana Terranova, *Network culture: politics for the information age*, Pluto Press, 2004.
- Steyerl Hito, 'Proxy Politics: Signal and Noise', *e-flux*, <http://www.e-flux.com/journal/proxy-politics/>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Steyerl Hito, 'The Spam of the Earth: Withdrawal from Representation', *e-flux*, <http://www.e-flux.com/journal/the-spam-of-the-earth/>. (Accessed December 10, 2021).
- Enwezor Okwui, 'The Postcolonial Constellation : Contemporary Art in the State of Permanent Transition', *Research in African Literatures*, Volume 34, Number 4, Winter 2003, pp. 57-82. Published by Indiana University Press.

Understanding Art

Course Code: VA-2079-1

(Offered in Summer 2024)

Course Instructor – Janice Pariat

Course Level – 2000 Elective

Course Prerequisites for students (if any) None

Detailed description of the Course:

This course explores the definitions of art developed by societies from the ancient Greeks to our globalised world. 'What is art?' is the question posed as we consider objects and activities in settings both remote in time and place and present around us. It attempts to build a critical language

for classifying and evaluating a broad range of visual forms of expression. The disciplines of aesthetics, hermeneutics, iconography, and iconology are explored in order to find an approach that works across the cultures East and West. The course looks into connoisseurship, taste, and the role of the institutions of the art world.

Bibliography of further readings

- Carroll, N. (1999) *Philosophy of Art: A Contemporary Introduction*, Routledge
- Freeland, C. (2001) *But is it art? An Introduction to Art Theory*, OUP.
- Graham, G. (2000/2005) *Philosophy of the Arts: An Introduction to Aesthetics*, Routledge.
- Sheppard, A. (1987) *Aesthetics: An Introduction to the Philosophy of Art*, OUP.
- Andina, Tiziana; Iacobelli, Natalia (2013) *The Philosophy of Art: The Question of Definition: From Hegel to Post-Dantian Theories*, Bloomsbury

Details of grading rubric for each and every course that we have taught - all grading components that we bring in to every course

Mid term and End of Term Presentations

Prepared for the presentation	/15
Organization: the presentation had a clear introduction, content, conclusion	/15
Demonstrated an understanding of the material	/20
Demonstrated critical thinking skills	/10
Demonstrated ability to take information from different sources and create something new	/20
Creativity—ideas were expressed in an innovative way	/10
Demonstrated time management skills by delivering a clear, concise presentation within the allotted time limit	/10
General comments	/100

End of term essays

Critical thinking skills, understanding of material, strength of argument, structure and organisation, creativity.

Learning outcomes

- Demonstrate knowledge in various theories of art from Plato to Danto
- Be familiar with the views of at least four philosophers of art
- Critically evaluate at least two of the major problems in the philosophy of art
- Distinguish between classificatory and evaluative approaches to art
- Formulate their own critical responses to theories and problems in the philosophy of art

Attendance/ Participation Policy for students

Students are permitted to miss THREE classes per semester. Beyond which there is half a grade cut (from class participation and attendance) for each subsequent missed class.

VA-3007: Visual Culture of Modern and Contemporary South Asia**Level: 2000-3000, Elective Course****No Pre-requisite****Instructor: Sraman Mukherjee**

This course sets out to explore the field of visual culture as it has developed at the intersections of disciplinary domains of history, art history, cultural and visual anthropology, film and media studies and heritage studies. With a specific focus on modern and contemporary South Asian societies, it will examine the shifting nature and function of visual imagery in the modern and contemporary era, the changing technologies of production and reproduction, and the different circuits of reception, dissemination and circulation of images. Interdisciplinary in its appeal and content, the course will introduce students to a wide range of sites and media of cultural productions ranging from painting, photography and popular prints to maps, archaeological relics, religious icons, public architecture and monumental statuary; from sites of display and spectatorship in museums and exhibitions to temples and urban spaces; from worlds of scholarship to those of devotion and tourism; from celluloid images of films and television to the interactive domain of the world wide web. Placing these visual forms and practices within the particular historical and political contexts of colonialism, decolonization, state building and globalization, the course will address broader theoretical concerns about the centrality of nationalism, class, ethnicity, diaspora, religion, gender and sexualities in the constitution of modern and contemporary South Asian public spheres. Exploring “vision” as constructed by physiological and social conditioning, we will map questions around boundaries between visual images and verbal texts, “Art” and “non-art”. Finally, through archives of images we will explore the different and often competing representations of South Asia both in the specific geographic region demarcated thus and in other parts of the globe among “Asians” and “non-Asian” communities in the diaspora.

Grading Rubric

This course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading through the entire semester including active class and site visit participation, and mid semester and end semester evaluations. The assessment and grading criterion are as follows:

- 1) Students will be assessed on basis on their active engagement with course contents which will carry ten percent (10%) of the total course grades.
- 2) The mid semester assessment will comprise of a class presentation and subsequent submission of an essay based on any one image chosen by the student in consultation with the instructor. The mid semester evaluation will carry 40% of the total course grades.
- 3) For the end semester evaluation candidates are required to write an essay between 2000 and 2500 words (including footnotes and bibliography). The topic of the end semester assessment has to be decided by the student in conjunction with the course instructor. The end semester assessments for this course will follow a feed forward method and students are actively encouraged to submit (within date and time specified) 2 working drafts/ drafts in progress to the course instructor for comments and feedback. The end semester assessment will carry 50% of the total course grades.

4) All submissions including mid semester and end semester papers have to be made electronically.

Learning Outcomes

On successful completion of the course, we will be able to

- A) Outline the main trends in the development of the field of visual culture
 - B) Evaluate the approaches of art historians, historians and anthropologists to the visual arts and material culture of South Asia.
 - C) Identify and analyse aspects of South Asia's visual images using appropriate vocabulary.
-

Contemporary Drawing

Course Code: VA 1040-1

Instructor: Anni Kumari

Course Level Elective 1000

Course Prerequisites for students (if any) None

Course Description:

The course introduces students to various perspectives and approaches that define contemporary drawing practices, emphasizing the renewed interest in drawing as a potential research and communication medium. It includes discussions and slide presentations as well as practical sessions. Focusing on developing an individualistic style to communicate personal stories, narratives and perspectives, the course offers students the opportunity to experiment at formal and conceptual levels.

Requirements (Reading List and other materials)

Reading list

- Phaidon editors. Vitamin D2: New Perspectives in Drawing. Phaidon Press, 2018.
- Marshall, Russell and Sawdon, Phil, eds. Hyperdrawing: Beyond the Lines of Contemporary Art. I B Tauris & Company Limited, 2012

Material List

- A Sketch-book, paper, black marker, Charcoal sticks and some graded pencils(to be procured by the students)

Grading Rubric

The course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading throughout the semester including active class participation and end semester evaluations.

The assessment and grading criterion is as follows:

- 1) Continuous assessment on the basis of attendance and class assignments.

2) End semester assessment comprising of project display and presentation. You will be graded on the clarity and precision with which you present your works and the context in which you want others to perceive it.

Distribution of grades in terms of weightage

Attendance	Class Assignments	Project Display	Presentation	Total
10	30	40	20	100

Learning outcomes

At the end of the course a student is expected to have

- An understanding of the issues, concerns and challenges that define contemporary drawing practices
- Experience of working with several drawing mediums
- A portfolio of drawings that could potentially be developed into a zine, artist book, graphic novel or illustrations for digital media.

Attendance/ Participation Policy for students

Up to four absences need no prior permission.

Monotype Printmaking

Course Code: VA 106-1

Instructor: Anni Kumari

Course Level: Elective 1000

Course Prerequisites for students (if any) None

Course Description

This is a studio-based, practice-led course that allows students to explore a wide range of materials and processes that lead to a print. It involves a fluid approach combining drawing, painting and printmaking techniques, in an individualistic style. The course is aimed at facilitating students to practically experiment with forms, colours, and textures and see their translation from one medium to another, finally culminating in a series of prints.

Process: Monotype printmaking or ‘Monotyping’ is an innovative process of creating a single print on paper. A monotype is a hybrid of drawing and printmaking. The artist would draw on a plate; the plate would be sandwiched with a piece of paper and run through a press. It goes through the press once and then the image is pulled off onto the sheet of paper.

Requirements (Reading List and other materials)

Material Requirements

1. Sketchbook (min size 10X12 inches, min 50 pages)
2. Graded Pencils (B, 2B, 4B, 6B, H)
3. Cartridge Sheets (min 250 gsm, 20 sheets)

4. Brushes (Round 0, 2,4,6,8,10; Flat 4, 10)
5. Charcoal, Black/Brown Conte/Dry pastels
6. Oil paints
7. Cutter, scissors
8. Masking tape (1 inch thick)

Grading Rubric

The course follows a pattern of continuous assessment and grading throughout the semester including active class participation and end semester evaluations.

The assessment and grading criterion is as follows:

- 1) Continuous assessment on the basis of attendance and class assignments.
- 2) End semester assessment comprising of project display and presentation. You will be graded on the clarity and precision with which you present your works and the context in which you want others to perceive it.

Distribution of grades in terms of weightage

Attendance	Class Assignments	Project Display	Presentation	Total
10	30	40	20	100

Learning outcomes

At the end of the course a student is expected to have

- Exposure to the various stages of translating a concept/idea into a visual form
- An understanding of drawing fundamentals , mediums and processes
- An experience of working with printmaking pigments , tools and techniques
- A portfolio of prints

Attendance/ Participation Policy for students

Up to four absences need no prior permission.

Image Gallery



Museum Class at Anubhav Gallery, National Museum of India New Delhi

Page 94 | 104



Gallery Class, National Museum of India, New Delhi



Museum Class, National Handloom and Handicrafts Museum, New Delhi



Students out on a field trip to Lodi Art District. March 2023



Students showing their work in a self-curated exhibition *Fool's Paradise* as an outcome of the course **Arts of Our Times II**, May 2023, Ashoka University.



Students led on a curated walk by the Founder, Director Mr. Aditya Arya, at Museo Camera, Gurugram. As part of field work from the course On Photography. A field trip was arranged by the department to the museum. March 2023.



From the exhibition *Blue and Other Things*. An exhibition curated by students from the course *Collectivism in Arts*. May 2022. The works were generously donated for the exhibition by Terrain Art.

Students' Testimonials and Current affiliations

Debaleena Bagchi – MLS (2023) currently working as researcher with Museum of Art and Photography, Bangalore. Enrolled at BARD NYU for integrated PhD.

“Being a part of the Visual Arts department during my MLS has been a truly transformative experience. The courses, *Histories of South Asian Art* and *Decorative Arts*, not only laid a robust foundation but also introduced us to a host of important ideas and nuances of South Asian art history. What was even more transformational was the opportunity to conduct Independent Study Modules with the department. The practice-oriented approach to research played a pivotal role in shaping the core of my thesis during these ISMs. Moreover, creating original art works in the two ISMs culminated in a solo exhibition!

My decision to come to Ashoka was strongly motivated by a pursuit of interdisciplinary studies which would have remained utterly incomplete without the opportunities offered by the VA department.

And finally, what really set the VA department's offering apart were the insightful and meticulously organised field visits to relevant spaces in Delhi which solidified the concepts discussed in class and also served as the greatest of exposures.

The guidance and support I have received from the VA department has truly made my MLS experience unique and worthwhile.”

Abhinanda Lahiri MLS 2022

“I pursued my Master’s in Liberal Studies(MLS) with the Visual Arts Department at Ashoka University(2022), after graduating from the Young India Fellowship(2019). I had the fortune of writing my art-historical thesis, entitled “Re-viewing Home, Rethinking Revival: Deconstructing the Complex Site of the Chamba Rimal” under my incredible supervisors at the Department of Visual Arts, which received an Academic Award from the Department. As a practice-led researcher of Western Himalayan textiles, I had the fantastic chance to be on-field for my thesis research, while undertaking multiple courses focusing on art historical methods, material histories of the Western Himalayas, and performative practices in craft. These courses made a deep impact on me as a student of South Asian Art History and made me self-aware of my personal context as a researcher on field and on paper, as I began formalising my career in research and academia. Courses like Methods in Art History gave me the knowledge, wisdom and courage to develop original research methodologies and question existing methods in the South Asian context in my thesis. Visual and Material Culture of the Himalayas brought me closer to my specific region of interest and its peoples. It made space for multiple insights and perspectives into Western Himalayan material cultures that helped me immensely to navigate and read the field, and to be fearless with seeking questions.

And, Crafting Identities in Central India: Arts, Crafts and Performative Practices was invaluable when I was reading the data I collected on field, analysing it and forming my arguments. These experiences pushed me to begin with my Phd applications, post graduating. While I am in this process, I have parallelly been working as a Field-Researcher for Centre for Pastoralism in the Himachal Himalayas. I am co-leading the team that is working on a study that is, for the first time ever, attempting to quantify the pastoral economy of Himachal Pradesh. This field is colliding with my specific area of research interest, allowing me to closely explore and develop concepts for my doctoral studies simultaneously. I am indebted to Ashoka University, the VA Department and my outstanding professors, who supported me every step of the way, and pushed me to dream big and then go for it, no matter what.

Akshaj Awasthi

ASP 2022

currently pursuing MPhil in Islamic Art & Architecture, University of Oxford (2023-25)

Ashoka University, Class of 2021/22

The Department of Visual Arts at Ashoka has been a space I was fortunate to study in from the Monsoon 2019 semester (during my second year of study at the university), right until my last semester of the Ashoka Scholars Programme in Spring 2022.

All the courses I had the privilege of enrolling in hosted by the Department were electives in the History of Art—representing varied geographic and methodological frameworks, often in conversation with other academic disciplines. These ranged from visual culture studies and visual anthropology of the Himalayas, the arts of the book in early modern South Asia, Mughal painting and material culture, the rock-cut caves of the Western Deccan during the ancient and early medieval periods, as well as long-durée surveys of South Asian art history. Every single course from these offerings had an indelible effect on my growth as a student of the discipline and suffused my own research while still at Ashoka: both as an undergraduate student majoring in History, when I conducted research on Mughal and Ottoman art, as well as in my ASP research on Asaf Jahi Hyderabad. It was with great assurance that I chose to write my ASP Capstone Thesis in the auspices of the Department of Visual Arts during the 2021-22 academic year, and I received immense support from my supervisors, the ASP thesis coordinator as well as the incumbent Head of Department. The department granted me the methodological tools to structure my research and ask the right questions—a large credit is due to the Methods in Art History course for this—and provided ample academic freedom to pursue my own line of argument, even if it differed at times from that of my own mentors. Members of the department respected my research, despite it emanating from a pre-doctoral thesis context, and even encouraged me to publish it. This support was vital in ensuring that some of my ASP thesis research was eventually published. The Department is one of the least insular spaces in terms of academic discipline out of the various Humanities departments Ashoka University possesses. It is proactive in cross-listing courses with other departments, and welcomes students from Philosophy, History, English and even Mathematics to bring their own disciplinary training and methodological lenses to the

study of art history. Consequently, it is unsurprising that the student research it has produced so far is a microcosm of Ashoka's promise of true interdisciplinarity. My own thesis, for example, beyond the staple bread-and-butter art-historical tools of formal analysis, also embraced ideas from both emerging and established disciplines such as material culture studies, book history, and literature. Without the significant intellectual growth I experienced while a student there, I would not have been academically equipped to be accepted into my graduate program of choice at Oxford, and that too with full funding. In my opinion, therefore, it is truly an academic space worth supporting.

Diya Shah

ASP 2022

The Art History courses at Ashoka University, albeit limited, have been some of the most enriching and detailed courses I have taken. Filling in the gaps for the lack of visual sources and material culture often forgotten in history courses, the visual arts department has succeeded in filling in this lacunae. The small classrooms and experienced professors have urged the students to have interesting class discussions that have helped me even in my professional career moving forward- noticing trends and movements in the art world, highlighting historical sources often shrouded by literary sources and the importance of soft power. The visual arts department and the art history courses are something I would recommend to all Ashoka students irrespective of their majors and minors!

Upasana Dandona

UG 2022

MA South Asian Area Studies at SOAS

"I had taken a photography course with the Visual Art department during my last semester and that genuinely laid a great foundation for the theories I'd have to work with for my grad school modules. We discussed the writings of Sontag, Pinney, Benjamin among others in great detail without rushing through them which only made the concepts clearer to us. Additionally, the feedback from my professors helped me improve my photography skills and overcome the minute errors I'd constantly make earlier. Thus, not only was I able to gain an understanding of the various theoretical texts, but even work on my skills."

In Memory of



Professor Kavita Singh

6 November 1964 - 30 July 2023

The Department of Visual Arts at Ashoka University is indebted to Professor Kavita Singh, part of our esteemed Board of Studies panel. She provided formative mentorship to the program. An erudite scholar, a generous educator and a visionary institution builder, her elegant and electrifying presence has left an indelible mark on all who knew her. The department will miss an excellent colleague and a dear friend.

Department of Visual Arts

